



CITY: Pg 3

CM Gupta reviews clean-air innovations



NATION: Pg 5

CDS: Future wars will be multi-domain with cyber and cognitive aspects



FILM: Pg 12

'It is not on purpose'

'US ENERGY CAN DIVERSIFY INDIA'S SUPPLY'

PM Modi-Rubio talks: WH invite, Iran warning and strategic push

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the visiting US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Saturday held wide ranging discussions focusing on the West Asia crisis and ways to bolster bilateral ties in crucial sectors, including defence, strategic technologies, trade and energy security.

The Modi-Rubio meeting indicated progress and a positive way forward in India-US relations as they discussed "defence, strategic technologies, trade and investment, connectivity, education and people-to-people ties".

Rubio, who landed in Kolkata in the morning then embarked on his trip to the national Capital also "shared US perspective on various regional and global issues, including the situation in West Asia," according to a statement from the Prime Minister's Office.

US State Department spokesperson Tommy Pigott



Prime Minister Narendra Modi meets US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, in New Delhi, on Saturday

BILATERAL BOOST

» The Modi-Rubio meeting indicated progress and a positive way forward in India-US relations as they discussed 'defence, strategic technologies, trade and investment, connectivity, education and people-to-people ties'

» According to the Prime Minister's Office, the Prime Minister reaffirmed India's consistent support for "peace efforts and reiterated the call for peaceful resolution of the conflicts through dialogue and diplomacy"

» Rubio underlined the importance of the US-India relationship

» "WE DISCUSSED THE SITUATION IN THE MIDDLE EAST AND US-INDIA PARTNERSHIP IN ENERGY, SECURING CRITICAL SUPPLY CHAINS, AND COLLABORATION ON EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES. I WAS PLEASED TO INVITE PRIME MINISTER MODI TO THE WHITE HOUSE ON BEHALF OF THE PRESIDENT"

said, "The Secretary and Prime Minister discussed the current situation in the Middle East. The Secretary emphasised that

the United States will not let Iran hold the global energy market hostage and affirmed that US energy products have

the potential to diversify India's energy supply". According to the Prime Minister's Office, the Prime

Minister reaffirmed India's consistent support for "peace efforts and reiterated the call for peaceful resolution of the

conflicts through dialogue and diplomacy". Rubio invited the prime minister on **Continued on P4**

Fuel hike nears Rs 5 in 10 days



Fuel meter keeps climbing

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Petrol and diesel prices were raised by 87-91 paise per litre on Saturday, taking the cumulative increase in retail fuel rates to nearly Rs 5 a litre in under 10 days.

Alongside, compressed natural gas (CNG) prices were raised by Re 1 per kg, marking the third increase in recent days and taking the cumulative hike to Rs 4 per kg.

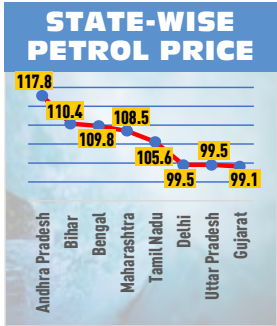
The latest revision pushed petrol prices higher by 87 paise per litre and diesel by up to 91 paise across the country, according to industry sources.

The back-to-back increases follow a prolonged freeze in retail fuel prices and come amid elevated crude oil prices in the global market, tightening refining margins, and a weaker rupee, which have sharply raised the cost of imports.

Petrol price was increased by 87 paise in Delhi to Rs 99.51 per litre from Rs 98.64 earlier. Similarly, diesel price was hiked by 91 paise to Rs 92.49 a litre from Rs 91.58 previously.

With the latest hike, petrol and diesel prices have risen to nearly Rs 5 a litre since the state-owned oil marketing companies on May 15 ended the hiatus in rate revision, stoking concerns over inflationary pressures and higher transportation costs across the economy.

Petrol and diesel prices were increased by Rs 3 per litre



FUEL FIRE

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» 'Ache Din for PR, hardship for people': Cong, AAP slam Modi govt over third fuel price hike

each on May 15 and 90 paise a litre on May 19.

CNG price in Delhi was increased to Rs 81.09 per kg from Rs 80.09, according to information posted by Indraprastha Gas Ltd on its website.

Rates have increased in all the neighbouring cities as well. **Continued on P4**

One of biggest drug hauls at IGI Airport

Hydroponic weed worth ₹48 cr seized from two Thai nationals

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In one of the biggest narcotics seizures at IGI Airport in recent times, Customs officials have seized suspected hydroponic weed worth around Rs 48 crore from two Thai nationals who arrived from Bangkok, officials said on Saturday.

Delhi Airport Customs Commissioner Arvind Saran said the seizure was among the largest narcotics recoveries made at any international airport in the country in recent years.

"Customs officials at the Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport are maintaining strict round-the-clock vigil to check attempts to smuggle drugs and other prohibited items," Saran said. **Continued on P4**

US, Iran close to truce deal?

There's been some progress made: US Secretary of State

ASSOCIATED PRESS

ISLAMABAD: The United States and Iran are close to agreeing on a memorandum of understanding aimed at ending the war, two regional officials and a diplomat said Saturday, as the United States has weighed a new round of attacks on the Islamic Republic.

Iran signalled "narrowing differences" in negotiations with the US after Pakistan's Army chief held more talks in Tehran, and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio told journalists in India that "there's been some progress made" and "there may be news later today."

The officials and diplomats expressed hope that a final decision on the Pakistan-prepared draft could come within 48 hours as both sides review it. They spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to brief the media.

They said Vice President JD Vance and envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner played significant roles in helping bridge remaining gaps, and that Qatar played a key role by sending a senior official to Tehran to support Pakistan's mediation efforts.

Still, both Iran and the US emphasised their key positions and have warned of the risks of resuming attacks. Iran state TV quoted Foreign Ministry spokesperson **Continued on P4**

KEY POINTS

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» The officials and diplomats expressed hope that a final decision on the Pakistan-prepared draft could come within 48 hours as both sides review it

'GOVT EMPOWERING YOUTHS'

'Rozgar Mela': PM Modi hands out 51K job letters



Candidates pose with their appointment letters during the 19th Rozgar Mela, in Jammu, on Saturday

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday virtually distributed appointment letters for central government jobs to more than 51,000 youths at a 'Rozgar Mela'.

Since the inception of 'Rozgar Mela' around 12 lakh recruitment letters have been issued through 18 such events held across the country. In his address, Modi said, "Today is a very important day for thousands of youths across the country. Today, more than 51,000 young people have received appointment letters for government jobs."

Today, all the recruited youths are becoming key partners in the country's journey of development. In railways, banking, defence, health, education and many other sectors, all the youths are about to take on

"TODAY, THE WORLD WANTS TO BE A PART OF INDIA'S DEVELOPMENT JOURNEY"

new responsibilities, he said.

"In the coming years, you all are going to play an important role in fulfilling the resolve for a developed India. For this achievement, I congratulate you, as well as your family members, very warmly," he said.

"Rozgar Mela reflects our government's commitment to empowering the 'Yuva Shakti' with new opportunities," he said.

Modi said the world is very excited about India's youth and technological progress.

"Today, the world wants to be a part of India's **Continued on P4**

MORE THAN 200 RESCUED

China mine blast kills 90

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

BEIJING: Ninety miners were killed in a gas explosion in a coal mine in north China, official media in Beijing reported on Saturday, adding that 201 miners have so far been rescued.

The gas explosion occurred at the Liushenyu coal mine on Friday evening. Rescue efforts are ongoing. The death toll rose to 90 following a coal mine accident in Qinyuan County in north China's Shanxi Province, state-run China Daily reported.

Chinese President Xi Jinping has issued instructions for a comprehensive rescue operation and treatment of

The gas explosion occurred at the Liushenyu coal mine on Friday evening. Rescue efforts are ongoing

the injured.

He has called for proper handling of the aftermath of the accident and sought a thorough investigation into its cause, with accountability pursued in accordance with the law.

Xi has stressed that authorities across the country must learn from the accident, remain vigilant on workplace safety, and intensify efforts to identify and eliminate potential risks to prevent major accidents. **See P6**

CITES SECURITY REASON

Govt asks Delhi Gymkhana Club to hand over premises by June 5

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The elite nearly a century-old Delhi Gymkhana Club was jolted with the stark possibility of closing down as the Centre on Saturday asked it to return its expansive 27.3 acres of land by June 5 on grounds of "securing defence infrastructure".

The Gymkhana Club has played host to national capitals' powerful and Who's Who at 2, Safdarjung Road, in the heart of leafy Lutyens' Delhi. The premises were leased



Delhi Gymkhana Club

to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd (now known as Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd) for maintaining a social and sporting club.

It stands adjacent to the prime minister's residence on

Lok Kalyan Marg on one of the city's most valuable and strategically important land parcels, within the high-security administrative zone that also houses several key central government and defence establishments.

An order, issued by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry on Friday, stated that the premises are critically required for the strengthening and securing of defence infrastructure and **Continued on P4**

LIGHT RAIN, STRONG WINDS, LITTLE RELIEF FOR DELHI

Heat siege across India, 16 die in Telangana

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Blistering heat and scorching summer winds swept across several parts of India on Saturday, pushing temperatures past 44 degrees Celsius in several regions. The punishing weather forced hospitals in Punjab to operationalise heat stroke management units, while the IMD issued a heatwave alert for three districts of Jharkhand for Monday.

The extreme conditions have begun to strain not just people, but also animals and birds, with veterinarians and animal rescuers in Delhi reporting exhausted pigeons dropping unconscious from the sky, dehydrated eagles



A man drinks water to quench his thirst amid scorching heat on Saturday

being picked up from roadsides, and street animals suffering from stomach toxicity amid the capi-

tal's relentless heatwave. Telangana Revenue Minister Ponguleti Srinivasa Reddy said

SCORCHER

» The extreme conditions have begun to strain not just people, but also animals and birds

» In Punjab and Haryana, intense hot weather conditions prevailed

» With heatwave conditions intensifying across several parts of the country, doctors are warning that prolonged exposure to high temperatures may adversely affect not only physical well-being but also eye and neurological functioning

16 people have died in seven districts of the state due to heatwave conditions prevailing in the state

during the current summer.

He directed officials to identify villages recording very high temperatures, issue heat alerts to such villages and ensure availability of drinking water, buttermilk, and ORS packets at public places and work sites.

In Rajasthan, Chittorgarh emerged as the hottest place in the state in the last 24 hours at 44.2 degrees Celsius, as the meteorological department warned that temperatures were likely to rise further from Sunday, with severe heatwave conditions expected in isolated pockets.

According to the weather department, the weather in most parts of the state is likely to remain dry over **Continued on P4**

Twisha case: Husband remanded

MPOST BUREAU

BHOPAL: A local court on Saturday remanded Samarth Singh, husband of former actor-model Twisha Sharma and an accused in her alleged dowry death case, in police custody for seven days, while his mother and co-accused Giribala Singh said the police were yet to contact her for recording her statement in the high-profile case.

A four-member team of doctors from AIIMS Delhi was slated to fly to Bhopal in the evening to conduct a second autopsy of Twisha Sharma following the Madhya Pradesh High Court's order.

Samarth Singh, who had been absconding for ten days after an FIR was registered against him and his mother following Twisha's death by hanging, was arrested on Friday evening after he reached the Jabalpur district court premises to surrender. He had withdrawn his pre-arrest bail petition filed in the Madhya Pradesh High Court earlier.

He was taken to Bhopal in the wee hours of Saturday and produced before Judicial Magistrate First Class Anudita Gupta who sent him in police custody for seven days. His lawyer also handed over his passport to the court.

Twisha Sharma, 33, was found hanging at her matrimonial home in Bhopal's Katara Hills area on May 12, following which an FIR was registered against her husband Samarth Singh who is a lawyer, and her **Continued on P4**

BHARAT AUDYOGIK VIKAS YOJNA (BHAVYA) SCHEME

Centre opens 4-month window for states to apply for 50 industrial parks

It aims to develop world-class industrial infrastructure, unlock manufacturing potential and drive the country’s economic growth

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Saturday said it has opened a four-month window for states to submit applications for setting up 50 industrial parks under the Rs 33,660 crore Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA) scheme.

On March 18, the Union Cabinet approved the scheme for developing 100 plug-and-play industrial parks across the country.

It aims to develop world-class industrial infrastructure, unlock manufacturing potential and drive the country’s economic growth.

Briefing the media on the subject, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said applications from states are being invited for 20 parks in the first two months and for another 30 in the subsequent two months.

These 50 parks will be approved in the first phase, and the remaining 50 in the next phase.

The scheme will be implemented in partnership with states and private sector players.

Under the scheme, indus-



Briefing the media on the subject, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said applications from states are being invited for 20 parks in the first two months and for another 30 in the subsequent two months

trial parks ranging from 100 to 1,000 acres will be taken up for development, he said.

The financial support of up to Rs one crore per acre will be provided for infrastructure development, the commerce and industry minister said.

For hilly states, a park can also be approved on 25 acres of land.

The selection process will be through a “challenge method”, and states that provide better facilities, such as land, water and power, are likely to attract investors, Goyal said, add-

Highlights

» These 50 parks will be approved in the first phase, and the remaining 50 in the next phase. The scheme will be implemented in partnership with states & private sector players

» Under the scheme, industrial parks ranging from 100 to 1,000 acres will be taken up for development, the commerce minister said

» The selection process will be through a ‘challenge method’ & states that provide better facilities, such as land, water & power, are likely to attract investors, he said

We are looking for applications for 50 industrial parks so that we can quickly start rolling out the scheme across the country,” he said.

There is also a provision under the scheme for states to partner with private players and submit proposals, under which the Centre will provide assistance of Rs 50 lakh per acre, Goyal said.

States should set up a special purpose vehicle (SPV), notify a planning authority and establish a single-window clearance mechanism to ensure faster approval of their applications.

“We expect that in three years, these 50 parks will be operationalised,” Goyal said.

By fostering cluster-based development and enabling co-location of industries, suppliers, and service providers, BHAVYA will strengthen domestic supply chains, promote regional industrialisation, and create new opportunities for millions of people.

The scheme will benefit manufacturing units, MSMEs, startups, and global investors seeking ready-to-use industrial infrastructure.

No nationwide shortage and fuel supply issues highly localised: IOC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), the nation’s largest oil firm, on Saturday said there was no overall shortage of petrol and diesel in the country and described fuel outages reported at some retail outlets as “highly localised” and temporary, caused by regional demand-supply mismatches and shifting sales patterns.

The state-owned fuel retailer said higher demand at certain outlets was driven by a seasonal rise in diesel consumption during the harvesting season, migration of customers from private pumps where retail prices were relatively higher, and increased institutional purchases at public sector outlets as bulk fuel supplies were being priced in line with elevated international rates.

The company said petrol sales during May 1-22 rose 14 per cent year-on-year, while diesel sales increased around 18 per cent, reflecting “sustained and exceptionally high” growth in demand that it continued to meet across the country.

In a statement, IOC said it “wishes to reassure customers and the general public that there is no overall shortage of petrol and diesel in the country. The current situation being witnessed at certain retail outlets is highly localised and temporary in nature, arising due to local demand-supply imbalances and redistribution of sales patterns in select areas.”

It said only a “very small number” of outlets in its net-



The company said petrol sales during May 1-22 rose 14 per cent year-on-year, while diesel sales increased around 18 per cent

work of more than 42,000 fuel stations had witnessed supply disruptions, while stocks and supplies at the majority of pumps remained normal and adequate.

The higher demand being witnessed at some locations is attributable to “seasonal increase in diesel demand during the ongoing harvesting period, temporary shift of customers from certain private retail outlets, owing to relatively higher retail prices at some private pumps, and increased migration of institutional and commercial demand to PSU retail outlets, as bulk and institutional supplies are currently priced significantly higher in line with prevailing interna-

tional market prices”.

IOC added that state-owned oil marketing firms continued to maintain sufficient fuel inventories nationwide and were taking steps to address isolated disruptions and ensure uninterrupted supplies. “Despite this sustained and exceptionally high growth in demand, IndianOil continues to consistently meet customer requirements across the country.” It also urged consumers to avoid panic buying, reiterating its commitment to maintaining seamless fuel availability across the country.

“IndianOil, along with other oil marketing companies (OMCs), continues to maintain adequate overall stocks and supplies of petrol and diesel across the country,” the statement said.

“The company is closely monitoring the situation and taking adequate measures to address these isolated situations and ensure uninterrupted fuel supplies to consumers.”

IOC said it remains committed to maintaining seamless fuel availability across the country and requests customers to avoid unnecessary panic buying.

NTPC reports ₹8,747 cr profit for Q4 FY26

NEW DELHI: NTPC Ltd has announced its audited financial results for fourth quarter and financial year 2025-26, reporting a strong all-round performance driven by operational gains and strategic growth.

On a standalone basis, NTPC reported a total income of Rs 44,030 crore for Q4 FY26, registering a 6 per cent growth against Q3 FY26. Profit After Tax (PAT) for Q4 FY26 rose to Rs 8,747 crore up from Rs 4,987 crore for Q3 FY26.

For FY26 PAT increased by 18 per cent to Rs 23,162 crore from Rs 19,649 crore for FY25.

On a consolidated basis, NTPC Group’s PAT for FY26 rose by 15 per cent to Rs 27,546 crore from Rs 23,953 for FY25. The strong performance was bolstered by a 29 per cent increase in the share of joint venture profits, which reached Rs 2,864 crore. Subsidiaries also earned a profit of Rs 3,312 crore for FY26.

Group PAT for Q4 FY26 has increased to Rs 10,615 crore from Rs 5,597 crore in Q3 FY26.

NTPC’s Coal power stations continue to set industry benchmarks in operational efficiency. NTPC’s coal plants achieved a Plant Load Factor of 72.04 per cent during FY26, significantly outperforming the Rest of India Coal PLF of 63.20 per cent.

The results reinforce NTPC’s leadership position in India’s power sector, backed by sustained operational excellence and a diversified growth strategy. *MP01T*

Qatar Holding sells 48L shares of Adani Energy Solutions to Birla MF for ₹643 crore

NEW DELHI: Qatar Holding LLC, an affiliate of the sovereign wealth fund Qatar Investment Authority, has sold 48.05 lakh shares of Adani Energy Solutions to Birla Mutual Fund for Rs 643 crore through open market transactions, according to data available on the BSE.

Qatar Holding LLC offloaded 48,05,974 shares, representing a 0.40 per cent stake in Adani Energy Solutions, as per block deal data executed on Friday.

The shares were disposed of at an average price of Rs 1,339 apiece, taking the deal value to Rs 643.52 crore.

Meanwhile, Birla Mutual Fund acquired the same number of shares at the same price.

Following the completion of the transaction, shares of Adani

Energy Solutions on Friday rose 2.10 per cent to close at Rs 1,368 apiece on the BSE.

Last month, Adani Energy Solutions posted a marginal rise of 1.3 per cent in its consolidated net profit at Rs 723 crore for the quarter ended March 2026, supported by a rise in revenues.

The company had logged a net profit of Rs 714 crore in the year-ago period.

Its total income rose to Rs 7,588.08 crore from Rs 6,596.39 crore in January-March FY25, the company said.

In the entire fiscal, the net profit was at Rs 2,392.75 crore, over two-fold jump from Rs 921.69 crore as of March 31, 2025, and the total income rose to Rs 28,325.16 crore from Rs 24,446.55 crore, it added. *PTI*

NEW DELHI: The country’s exports have recorded healthy growth during the first three weeks of May, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Saturday.

He also said that while the world is going through a turmoil, India is relentlessly rising on global stage as it is recording health growth in exports and foreign direct investment (FDI).

“I have seen the numbers of exports even in the last three weeks. The pace of growth which we witnessed in April continues into May. We have been able to demonstrate resilience in the face of so many adversities,” he told reporters here.

Exports rose by 13.78 per cent to \$43.56 billion in April, the highest monthly outbound shipments in more than four years, driven by petroleum products amid a surge in crude

FDI during 2025-26 has touched an all time high of \$95 bn, an increase of 17% year on year

oil prices, but trade deficit widened to a three-month high of \$28.38 billion due to an uptick in imports.

The minister said that FDI during 2025-26 has touched an all time high of \$95 billion, an increase of 17 per cent year on year. This growth, he said, will continue in the years to come given the favour that India enjoys amongst global investors as a preferred investment destination.

“The government has absorbed significant amounts of costs, particularly for the farmers in terms of elevated fertiliser prices, which have not

been passed on to farmers, but the burden has been taken fully by the central government,” he added. He said that the government is also continually introducing initiatives to support economic growth.

For May, the commerce ministry will officially release the export and import data on June 15.

The high growth in FDI reflects global investors’ appetite for India.

Talking about the semiconductor sector, he said that Tata and ASML have joined hands to set up a plant in Dholera, Gujarat, which is a big achievement in itself.

“Because I still remember, when the semicon mission was launched 3 years ago, then ASML was hesitating. And there is no chip that can be made without ASML equipment. It is a compulsion that you need ASML equip-

ment. So you see, what a big change in 3 years. From no to yes,” Goyal said.

ASML is known for having a monopoly in a category of lithography equipment, which is critical for the production of advanced small-sized semiconductors.

Electronics manufacturing company Tata Electronics and Dutch semiconductor equipment major ASML have joined hands to enable chip manufacturing in India.

He informed that the ministry has held an inter-ministerial meeting with industry associations on ways to boost domestic manufacturing.

The ministry has received suggestions from sectors such as capital goods, optical fibres and chemicals.

In the meeting, he said the ministry has shared import data and data on sectors with export potential. *PTI*

Govt does not interfere in exchange rates: Goyal

NEW DELHI: The government does not interfere in exchange rates as these are determined by market forces and influenced by several global factors, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Saturday.

However, the government is always conscious of taking steps to promote exports, reduce import dependence and promote a greater degree of investment into India, he said.

“The government does not interfere in the exchange rate. It is a matter of market forces, and it is also dependent on several global factors. In fact, if I read correctly, in the last two or three days, again the rupee has appreciated pretty significantly. So, these are market-driven factors,” he said.

The rupee rose for the second consecutive session on May 22 to close sharply higher at 95.60 against the US dollar on softening of crude oil prices and supposed intervention by the Reserve Bank.

The rupee’s sharp decline has emerged as one of the biggest economic warning signs for policymakers, investors and businesses.

Once considered among Asia’s more stable currencies, the rupee has now become one of the worst-performing emerging market currencies this year, pressured by a toxic mix of expensive oil, capital outflows, widening trade deficits and a surging US dollar. *PTI*

Consumers get major relief through CM Electricity Bill Payment Resolution Scheme

RAIPUR: Under the Good Governance Festival 2026, Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai attended a Solution Camp organised in Karhibazar of Balodabazar district. During the event, he interacted with beneficiaries of various government schemes and gathered information about the benefits they were receiving.

At the camp, many consumers received relief in their electricity bills under the Chief Minister Electricity Bill Payment Resolution Scheme 2026.

Beneficiaries stated that the scheme had provided them financial relief and significantly reduced their worries regarding pending electricity bills.



In Balodabazar district, Asharam, a resident of village Bitkuli, received a waiver of Rs 11,625; Babul received Rs 14,922; Jagdish received Rs 9,832; Budhyarin received Rs 8,467; and Chovaram received Rs 13,325 as relief.

During discussions with the Chief Minister, beneficiaries shared that earlier they faced financial difficulties due to high electricity bills, but the Chief Minister Electricity Bill Payment Resolution Scheme had provided them major relief.

They said they are now able to pay their electricity bills regularly without any additional burden.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai said that the objective of the state government is to provide relief to the common people and resolve their problems with sensitivity. He added that the government is continuously working to ensure that assistance reaches every section of society through welfare schemes.

The beneficiaries expressed gratitude to the Chief Minister and the state government, stating that the scheme is proving to be a major support for economically weaker families. *MP01T*

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE

REC Power Development & Consultancy Ltd (RECPDCL) and Bihar State Power Transmission Company Ltd (BSPTCL) have officially signed a landmark Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to develop intra-state transmission projects through the Tariff Based Competitive Bidding (TBCB) mode. The signing ceremony was attended by the Energy Minister, Govt. of Bihar, Shailesh Kumar. Also in attendance were key administrative leaders, including Ajay Yadav (IAS), Energy Secretary & CMD of BSPHCL, Prince Dhawan (IAS), Chief Executive Officer of RECPDCL, and Rahul Kumar (IAS), MD of BSPTCL, alongside senior officials from the Energy Department of the Government of Bihar, BSPTCL, and BSPHCL. *MP01T*

Goldman Sachs, Societe Generale & others buy 1.34% stake in Paytm for ₹963 cr

Other foreign investors included Ghisallo Capital Management, BNP Paribas, Cophall Mauritius Investment & Viridian Asset Management (Hong Kong)

NEW DELHI: Global financial institutions, including Goldman Sachs, Societe Generale, and Citigroup Global Markets, have collectively acquired a 1.34 per cent stake in One 97 Communications, the parent company of Paytm, from SAIF Partners and Elevation Capital for Rs 963 crore through open market transactions.

Other foreign investors participating in the transaction included Ghisallo Capi-

tal Management, BNP Paribas, Cophall Mauritius Investment, and Hong Kong-based Viridian Asset Management.

Among domestic institutional investors, Sundaram Mutual Fund (MF), Nippon India MF, Edelweiss Mutual Fund and India Acorn ICAV also bought shares of the fintech firm, as per the block deal data executed on the BSE on Friday.

These entities collectively

purchased a total of 85.98 lakh shares on the exchange, representing a 1.34 per cent stake in Noida-based One97 Communications.

The shares were bought at an average price of Rs 1,120.65 apiece, taking the transaction value to Rs 963.60 crore.

Meanwhile, Hong Kong-based private equity firm SAIF Partners, through its affiliates — SAIF III Mauritius Company Ltd and SAIF Part-

CLOSER LOOK

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» The shares were bought at an avg price of Rs 1,120.65 apiece, taking the transaction value to Rs 963.60 crore

ners India IV Ltd — offloaded a combined 80.08 lakh shares

of Paytm. Further, Gurugram-based

venture capital firm Elevation Capital also disposed of 5.89 lakh shares in the fintech company. The shares were offloaded at the same price, as per the data on the BSE.

Following the transaction, SAIF Partners’ holding in One 97 Communications declined to 12.18 per cent from 13.43 per cent.

Shares of One 97 Communications on Friday declined nearly 4 per cent to close at Rs

1,112.50 apiece on the BSE.

In November 2025, PE firm SAIF Partners divested a 1.86 per cent stake in Paytm for Rs 1,556 crore.

Earlier this month, Paytm reported a consolidated profit of Rs 183 crore in the fourth quarter ended March 2026, a turnaround from a loss of Rs 545 crore in the same period a year ago.

The consolidated revenue from operations grew by 18.4

per cent to Rs 2,264 crore during the reporting quarter from Rs 1,912 crore in the March 2025 quarter.

During the financial year ended March 2026, Paytm posted a consolidated profit of Rs 552 crore compared to a loss of Rs 663 crore in FY25.

The annual revenue from the operations of Paytm grew by 22.2 per cent to Rs 8,437 crore in FY26 from Rs 6,900 crore in FY25. *PTI*

CM Gupta reviews clean-air innovations

Checks devices under ‘Innovation Challenge’



Rekha Gupta, Manjinder Singh Sirsa and MLA Harish Khurana during the inspection on Saturday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday inspected some of the newly installed air pollution mitigation devices in parts of the city under the government’s ‘Innovation Challenge’.

Gupta, along with Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, inspected pole-mounted dust catchers installed near the Kirti Nagar industrial area and central verge air purifiers set up at the Kirti Nagar fire station.

Last year in October, Sirsa launched the challenge for pollution reduction solutions, inviting individuals, startups, and research institutions to submit ideas aimed at reducing particulate matter (PM2.5 and PM10) emissions.

During the inspection, Sirsa explained that dust keeps getting collected in the device, and after about 15-20 days,

‘Delhi government to transform registrar offices’

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government plans to transform registrar offices into modern and citizen-centric service centres, modelled on the efficiency and time-bound service delivery seen at Passport Seva Kendras, the chief minister said on Saturday. Gupta said the city government will overhaul the capital’s property registration system, including “AI-powered facial recognition for identity verification, background checks and blockchain-backed record security”.

The backend technology alerts authorities once the units are full. “The device can collect dust from a radius of 400 square metres,” he said. Explaining to Gupta, Sirsa further pointed out that the device would be enclosed within an iron frame for protection.

The devices inspected on Saturday are among the 22 shortlisted innovations currently

undergoing trials in the next phase of the government’s innovation challenge to assess their effectiveness.

“Around 15-16 such pilot projects have been installed in parts of Delhi. Our aim is that if we find any such innovations and technology that can help clean Delhi’s air, then we will keep working on them,” Sirsa said.

Rain brings brief respite as Delhi sizzles above 44°C

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: After days of searing heat, strong winds, thunderstorms, and light rain in parts of Delhi brought much-needed respite to residents of the national capital early Saturday.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD), which had initially issued an orange alert, changed it to yellow for the day, warning of light rain and gusty winds. However, it said orange alerts remain in place from Sunday for the next five days, signalling a return of the intense heatwave.

According to IMD data till 8.30 am, the Ridge station received 0.2 mm of rain between 11.30 pm on Friday and 2.30 am on Saturday, while



Pusa logged 2 mm between 5.30 am and 8.30 am on Saturday. No significant rainfall was recorded elsewhere.

IMD said temporary relief from heatwave conditions is expected over northwest India, including Delhi, Punjab, Haryana, and Chandigarh, due to thunderstorm activity over the region, but temperatures are likely to rise again from Sunday onwards.

It said, wind speeds during the dust storm and thunderstorm activity early Saturday were recorded at up to 81 kmph at Pusa Road, 56 kmph at Palam, and 35 kmph at Pragati Maidan. A significant reduction in visibility was also recorded at Palam airport, where visibility dropped from 3,500 metres to 1,500 metres within one hour. However, IMD later informed that the current spell of winds and thunderstorms had moved southeastwards, away from Delhi. “Very light to light rain, accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning, and dust storms, is expected on Saturday. Strong surface winds of speed 40-50 kmph might also continue,” said an IMD official. Meanwhile, Safdarjung,

representative of the city’s weather, recorded a minimum temperature of 28.4 degrees Celsius on Saturday, 1.7 degrees above the season’s average and 0.9 degrees lower than the day before. “The fall in minimum temperatures by one to two degrees Celsius occurred over Delhi, as a result of which no warm night conditions prevailed,” the official said. The maximum temperature settled at 41.1 degrees Celsius. The city’s air quality index (AQI) was recorded at 201 (poor) at 8 pm on Saturday, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB). The Air Quality Early Warning System (AQEWS) for Delhi has forecast the AQI to remain in the poor category for the next few days.

Cousin kills woman, son over resentment

NEW DELHI: A 28-year-old man allegedly killed his cousin and her teenage son in south-east Delhi’s Govindpuri due to resentment over her repeatedly counselling him against drug addiction and criminal activities, police said on Saturday. The accused has been arrested following an encounter, they added. Accused Saurabh Sahu sustained a bullet injury in his leg during retaliatory firing after he allegedly opened fire at a police team at Tughlakabad Extension late on Friday night, officials said.

A sub-inspector narrowly escaped injury after a bullet struck his bulletproof jacket during the exchange of fire.

The killings came to light on the intervening night of May 20 and 21, when Sharda Sahu (38) and her 13-year-old son were found stabbed to death inside their residence in Govindpuri.

Soon after, multiple teams of southeast district police were formed to trace the accused. The investigation was carried out under the supervision of senior officers, with different teams analysing CCTV footage, examining electronic evidence and interrogating suspects and local contacts.

During the probe, investigators identified Saurabh Sahu, a resident of Sangam Vihar and cousin of the deceased woman, as the prime suspect. Acting on a specific tip-off about his movement near the Ghati Wala Park in Tughlakabad Extension, police laid a trap during the intervening night of May 22 and 23. The accused was spotted near the park and asked to surrender.

NDMC launches drive against dengue, malaria & Chikungunya

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With the onset of the monsoon season and rising concerns over mosquito-borne diseases, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has intensified its public awareness campaign on dengue, chikungunya and malaria prevention. Through posters, social media outreach and community messaging, the civic body has urged residents to adopt preventive measures and maintain cleanliness in and around their homes.

In an advisory issued on social media, NDMC highlighted a list of ‘do’s and don’ts’ aimed at preventing mosquito breeding. Residents have been advised to keep water tanks and containers properly covered, clean coolers regularly, and avoid stagnant water in

Highlights

- » Residents have been advised to keep water tanks and containers properly covered, clean coolers regularly, and avoid stagnant water in flower pots
- » The civic body also stressed the importance of wearing full-sleeved clothes, using mosquito repellents and sleeping under mosquito nets during the fever season

flower pots, buckets and discarded items such as tyres and bottles. The civic body also stressed the importance of wearing full-sleeved clothes, using mosquito repellents and

sleeping under mosquito nets during the fever season.

The advisory warned citizens against relying solely on platelet count during dengue treatment and cautioned against self-medication without consulting doctors. NDMC further appealed to citizens not to throw waste in open areas, as accumulated garbage and waterlogging become breeding grounds for mosquitoes during the rainy season.

Calling for collective participation, the civic body urged people to spread awareness within communities and cooperate in keeping neighbourhoods clean and hygienic. The campaign forms part of NDMC’s broader efforts to curb seasonal outbreaks and strengthen public health preparedness across the national capital.

MCD cancels Nehru Hill Park Eid allotment amid goat market row

NEW DELHI: Amid the allegations of operating illegal selling of goats in Nehru Hill Park near Ramlila Maidan, the MCD on Saturday cancelled the permission to use the site allotted for Eid celebrations, an official order said.

The move comes days after the civic body’s horticulture department had complained to Delhi police on May 12 and May 14 about the alleged illegal use of the park for buying and selling of goats.

In an official order issued on Saturday, the assistant director (Horticulture), City-SP Zone, said permission granted to a residents’ welfare association representative for use of the park from May 21 to May 27 stood “withdrawn/cancelled with immediate effect”.

The official order stated that “activities” were being carried out at the site in violation of the conditions of the permission granted.

“You are directed to vacate the site forthwith and remove all related activities/material from the premises immediately,” the order said, while seeking assistance from the IP Estate police station to ensure compliance.

The permission had reportedly been granted after payment of around Rs 1.07 lakh, Delhi BJP alleged.

According to the statement by the party, the issue has triggered protests from some local residents and BJP office bearers, who alleged that the allotment was being used to legitimise an illegal goat market at the public park located in the mixed-population locality around Mata Sundari Road and Minto Road.

A delegation led by Delhi BJP office bearer Amit Gupta met Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and demanded cancellation of the allotment, the statement read.

“There is no mention anywhere in the receipt about permission for a goat market. This is clearly a case of intimidating municipal officials and obtaining a receipt to legitimise an illegal activity,” Amit Gupta alleged in a statement.

He also claimed that no such goat market had been held at the park in the past several decades and questioned the allotment of a public park when the Delhi government had already stated that slaughtering of goats would not be allowed at public places.

500 SHOPS GUTTED; LOCALS PELT STONES AT FIRE TENDERS Market blaze fuels outrage over response delay

NEW DELHI: A massive fire gutted around 500 shops in the Shastri Park Furniture Market here on Friday night, triggering chaos as angry residents allegedly pelted stones at fire tenders over claims of a delayed response, officials said on Saturday.

Officials of the Delhi Fire Service (DFS) denied the allegations and said firefighting operations continued through the night. No casualties were reported, though the blaze caused property losses worth lakhs of rupees, they said.

According to police, information regarding the fire at the furniture market near New Seelampur metro station was received at Shastri Park Police Station in northeast New Delhi around 11:56 pm on Friday.

Around 200 police staff immediately reached the spot



Debris is seen after at the gutted furniture market in Shastri Park

and managed the crowd as multiple fire tenders carried out firefighting operations, they said. The fire spread rapidly due to the presence of highly combustible material such as wooden furniture and plywood, a DFS official said.

The official said the DFS received information about the

fire at 11:57 pm and fire tenders were dispatched immediately.

“The fire was later categorised as a medium category blaze. Wooden furniture and plywood were the main combustible materials at the site. Nearly 25-26 fire tenders were deployed to douse the fire,” the official said.

At around 12:50 am, police assistance had to be sought after some members of the public hurled stones at firefighting teams during the operation, the official said.

Some locals claimed that the fire tenders reached the spot late, causing traders to suffer major financial losses ahead of Eid-ul-Azha.

“The fire broke out around 11:15 pm, and fire tenders arrived almost an hour later. We do not know how the fire started in the two shops. The entire market has been destroyed, and only 20 shops remain unscathed. Everyone has suffered huge losses ahead of the festival,” a resident said. Police received a PCR call regarding the blaze at the Bata showroom in Mukherji Nagar around 6:52 am in northwest Delhi.

Government begins work on 12 DSTPs to clean Yamuna

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has started work on 12 decentralised STPs covering 120 unauthorised colonies to reduce waste entering the Najafgarh drain and clean the Yamuna river, officials said on Saturday.

In the recently held meeting, chief minister Rekha Gupta reviewed the progress of Yamuna cleaning, where the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) informed her about the work. Earlier this year, the Delhi government announced the setting up of 40 decentralised STPs (DSTPs) planned by the DJB across Delhi.

“The total estimated cost of the 12 DSTPs is around Rs 860 crore, which will be funded under the AMRUT initiative of the Central government. This will increase

the overall treatment capacity by around 40 MGD,” a senior government official said.

The Najafgarh drain has long carried floating waste, invasive weeds, and untreated pollutants into the Yamuna. “By targeting the problem at its source, this project is expected to significantly reduce the pollutant load entering the river while also improving drainage efficiency across the city,” officials said.

Colonies to benefit are Mitraon village, Sarangpur, Sikharpur, Hassanpur and Jaffarpur in Outer Delhi and others.

The Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT) scheme was launched by the Central government in 2015 to strengthen sewer-

age systems in urban cities.

In areas where large-scale sewage treatment plants (STPs) cannot be constructed due to space limitations, the DJB plans to install 40 DSTPs to ensure localised waste management.

Currently, the DJB has a sewage treatment capacity of around 600-700 million gallons per day (MGD) across all existing STPs. The government plans to increase this capacity to 1,250 MGD by June 2027. Investigators said the accused used these firms for bogus billing, fake GST transactions, and fraudulent ITC claims while concealing the financial trail through multiple bank accounts, mobile numbers and intermediaries.

Eviction at Gymkhana Club puts 600 jobs on line

‘Most of us are still waiting for clarity on what happens to our jobs’

NEW DELHI: Uncertainty loomed over nearly 600 employees of the iconic Delhi Gymkhana Club on Saturday after the Centre directed it to hand over its premises by June 5, leaving the staff anxious over their future amid a lack of clarity on job security and transition plans.

The order, issued by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry, said the 27.3-acre land in Lutyens’ Delhi was required for “urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and public interest project”, including strengthening defence-related infrastructure.

It further stated that “the



In Short

» Inside the sprawling premises located near Lok Kalyan Marg, the atmosphere on Saturday evening was marked by unease

» The Delhi Gymkhana Club stands on one of the city’s most valuable and strategically important land parcels, within the high-security administrative zone

Road were originally leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd (now Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd) for maintaining a social and sporting club, and are now required for broader public purpose projects linked with the adjoining government land.

Inside the sprawling premises located near Lok Kalyan Marg, the atmosphere on Saturday evening was marked by unease, with employees saying they had received no formal briefing from the management on the future course of action.

A staff member said workers came to know of the development only recently and were left unsettled by the abruptness of the order. “There has been no formal meeting with

employees so far. Most of us are still waiting for clarity on what happens to our jobs after June 5,” the employee said.

Among those affected are also long-serving workers who have spent decades maintaining the club’s facilities.

A gardener working at the tennis lawns, who has been associated with the club for 17 years, said he was carrying out his usual afternoon routine of trimming the grass and tending to the courts when he first heard about the development.

“I was in the lawn, cutting the grass and maintaining the court area as part of my regular duty when someone told me around 4 pm that the club may be shut down by early June,” he said.

‘BJP govt displacing people one by one’

NEW DELHI: AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj on Saturday alleged that the BJP-led government is “displacing people one by one” after the Centre issued an eviction notice to the Delhi Gymkhana Club, saying “everyone’s turn will come eventually”.

“Ever since the BJP government came to power, it has only displaced people and never rehabilitated anyone. Till now, it was the poor who were being affected, so the rich were not too bothered,” Bharadwaj said. He said the turn then came for shopkeepers, so salaried professionals did not feel affected, and now the turn of senior officers and professionals who visit clubs has come.

“Everyone’s turn will come eventually,” he said.

people do not feel the pain of others, others will not feel their pain either. In this way, the government will continue to act unchecked and displace people one by one. The day people begin to feel the suffering of others, they will start questioning the government,” he said.

The remarks came after the Centre asked the Delhi Gymkhana Club in Lutyens’ Delhi to hand over its premises by June 5, stating that the 27.3-acre land parcel was required for “strengthening and securing defence infrastructure” and other public security purposes.

A member of the club, Siddharth, said the order would be challenged through an appeal, asserting that there was no security threat linked to the premises.

According to JNUSU, the issue escalated when Aditya raised concerns regarding alleged medical negligence. The doctor allegedly threatened him with rustication and behaved aggressively when the student attempted to record the incident on his phone. The union further alleged that the doctor tried to snatch the phone and chased the student inside the premises, creating panic among those present.

Condemning the incident, JNUSU said students have the democratic right to question negligence and seek accountability without fear of harassment. The union demanded strict action against the doctor, protection for students raising complaints, and the establishment of a transparent grievance redressal mechanism at the Health Centre.

“INDIA HAS COME A LONG WAY AS FAR AS ITS DEFENCE INDUSTRY IS CONCERNED”

Rajnath: No power can stop India from being biggest exporter of weapons in 25-30 yrs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SHIRDI: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said no power can stop India, once considered an importer of weapons, from becoming the biggest exporter in 25-30 years.

After inaugurating an ammunition manufacturing unit in Shirdi, Singh said a nation that makes its weapons writes its own future.

He said the role of private players in defence manufacturing was negligible a few years back, which now stands at 25-30 per cent, while the government has set a target to increase it further to 50 per cent.

“The private sector is not just a supplier of nuts and bolts in defence, but also a producer of state-of-the-art weapons systems,” he added.



Union Defence minister Rajnath Singh addresses the inauguration ceremony of an ammunition manufacturing unit, in Shirdi, Ahilyanagar district, Saturday

Singh said India was considered a weapons importer, but no power can now stop it from being the biggest exporter in 25-30 years.

He said that when the government's vision and the pri-

ivate sector's innovation align, then the country reaches new heights.

“All have to work together to make India the hub of munitions and automation,” he added.

Highlights

» After inaugurating an ammunition manufacturing unit in Shirdi, Singh said a nation that makes its weapons writes its own future

» All have to work together to make India the hub of munitions and automation, said Rajnath

PTI

The main reason behind this was that private players did not get the opportunities and the sector was restricted to defence PSUs and ordnance factories, the defence minister said.

He listed steps undertaken by the Central government to increase private participation in the defence sector, including policy-related reforms and liberalisation of foreign direct investment.

He said India has come a long way as far as its defence industry is concerned.

Singh said that while ordnance factories existed even before Independence and the defence industry is deeply rooted in the country, after Independence, there was no balance between the country's old capabilities and modern requirements.

The main reason behind this was that private players did not get the opportunities and the sector was restricted to defence PSUs and ordnance factories, the defence minister said.

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All accounts, website taken down: CJP founder alleges crackdown

As the movement claims 10 lakh sign-ups

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Saturday alleged a sweeping crackdown on the satirical digital movement, claiming that all its social-media accounts as well as its website have been taken down or compromised, leaving the group without access to any of its official platforms.

Dipke said the outfit has lost access to its Instagram accounts, its X handle has been withheld in India, its backup account was briefly taken down and its website -- cockroach-jantaparty.org -- has also been taken down.

“Please note that we currently do not have access to any of our platforms. Any post made after this should not be considered an official statement from the Cockroach Janta Party,” Dipke said in a post on

X. Listing what he described as coordinated action against the movement, Dipke wrote, “Crackdown on Cockroach Janta Party. Instagram page hacked. My personal Instagram hacked. Twitter account withheld. Back up account also taken down.”

The claims came two days after the CJP's original X handle was withheld in India, prompting Dipke to create a new account. On Friday, he also alleged receiving death threats and shared screenshots of purported threat messages online.

The outfit had launched a campaign seeking Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged systemic failures in the education sector and the NEET-UG 2026 paper “leak.”

Linking the action against the platform to the campaign, Dipke said, “Action should have

been taken against the Education Minister for the paper leak. For the student who lost his life due to the government's failure. But in New India, action is being taken against the Cockroach Janta Party for demanding accountability.”

In fresh posts shared from the backup X handle -- “Cockroach is Back” -- the group claimed that its movement continues to grow despite the alleged crackdown.

“We have achieved 1 million registered cockroaches on our website in less than a week! The movement keeps getting bigger despite all the crackdown!” the CJP said.

The group claimed that before its website was taken down, “10 lakh cockroaches had signed up on our website as members” and “6 lakh cockroaches had signed a petition to demand the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan.”

From Page 1 Modi-Rubio

behalf of President Donald Trump to visit the White House in the “near future,” as the top American diplomat described India as the “cornerstone” of Washington's approach towards the Indo-Pacific.

The US Secretary of State's four-day trip to India -- aimed at holding wide-ranging talks with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and attending a Quad foreign ministers' conclave -- is largely seen as an attempt to recalibrate bilateral relations, which have faced headwinds since mid-last year.

Rubio underlined the importance of the US-India relationship.

“We discussed the situation in the Middle East and US-India partnership in energy, securing critical supply chains, and collaboration on emerging technologies. I was pleased to invite Prime Minister Modi to the White House on behalf of the President,” he said on ‘X’.

After the meeting with the prime minister, Rubio, at an event at the US embassy, described India as an “incredibly important partner” for the US and indicated that the two sides are planning to make certain important announcements in the coming months to further solidify the relations.

In his address, he delved into various aspects of India-US relations and touched upon how the friendship between PM Modi and President Trump is driving the ties forward. “The connection between the leaders is incredibly important. These are two very serious leaders who are focused not just on the short-term, but on the long-term. I think that that is important to note, because it's a key part of the foundation, the relationship between our countries,” Rubio said. The US Secretary of State also emphasised Washington's seriousness to expand cooperation under the Quad framework.

US State Department Spokesperson Tommy Pigott said the Secretary of State underscored the strategic importance of the US-India partnership, the strong personal ties between the US President and the Prime Minister, as well as the profound economic and commercial opportunities for the two sides.

Modi and Rubio also reflected upon bilateral achievements including significant investments that advance the President and the Prime Minister's “Mission 500” to double trade by 2030, he said.

According to an Indian read-out, Rubio briefed PM Modi on the “sustained progress in bilateral cooperation across a wide range of sectors, including defence, strategic technologies, trade and investment, energy security, connectivity, education and people-to-people ties.”

PM Modi reaffirmed India's consistent support for peace efforts and reiterated the call for peaceful resolution of the conflicts through dialogue and diplomacy, it said.

The readout from the Prime Minister's Office said Modi requested Secretary Rubio to convey his warm greetings to President Trump and said that he looked forward to their continued exchanges.

US Ambassador Gor, who was also part of the Rubio-led delegation, described the meeting with PM Modi as “productive.”

“We had a productive discus-

sion on ways to deepen US-India cooperation across security, trade, and critical technologies - areas that strengthen both our nations and advance a free and open Indo-Pacific. India is a vital partner to the United States!” he said on ‘X’.

The Secretary of State inaugurated the Support Annex Building, which the US Mission said will deliver critical consular services.

He also mentioned USD 20 billion in investments announced by Indian companies in the United States in recent months.

Earlier in the day upon his arrival in Kolkata, he visited the Mother House -- the headquarters of Saint Teresa's Missionaries of Charity -- before flying to the national capital.

On Sunday, Rubio is scheduled for bilateral talks with Jaishankar. The Secretary of State will travel to Agra and Jaipur on Monday before returning to Delhi on Tuesday morning for the Quad foreign ministers meeting.

Separately, Rubio told NDTV that Washington's new policy for permanent residency or green card is not directed at India as it is part of the Trump administration's approach to streamline the immigration system.

The new policy requires green card applicants to make their applications from their home countries.

Rubio's trip to India comes over five weeks after Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri undertook a three-day visit to Washington DC that focused on stabilising the ties after a spell of uncertainty and strain.

The relations between the two countries witnessed a major downturn after Washington imposed punitive tariffs on India and President Donald Trump made controversial assertions regarding his role in de-escalating the India-Pakistan military clashes last May.

Over the next few months, the US president repeatedly and publicly claimed that he had resolved the military conflict between the two neighbours and saved millions of lives as it was heading toward a full-scale war.

New Delhi stoutly maintained that the cessation of hostilities was the result of talks between India and Pakistan, and the US involvement had nothing to do with it. However, both sides made efforts in the last few months to repair the ties.

The two sides resolved to firm up a mutually beneficial trade deal soon.

President Trump and PM Modi held a nearly 40-minute phone conversation on April 14.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Fuel hike

This is the third increase in CNG prices, and together with the earlier hikes of Rs 2 per kg on May 15 and Re 1 per kg on May 17, it takes the cumulative increase to Rs 4 per kg.

On all three occasions, private fuel retailers like Nayara Energy swiftly matched the price increases announced by their state-owned rivals, raising petrol and diesel rates by a similar quantum.

The latest increases came on top of hikes effected earlier by private retailers ahead of the first fuel price revision on May 15 by state-run oil companies.

Nayara Energy had raised petrol and diesel prices by Rs 5 and Rs 3 per litre, respectively, in March, while Shell increased petrol prices by Rs 7.41 a litre and diesel by as much as Rs 25 per litre from April 1.

Jio-BP, the fuel retailing joint venture of Reliance Industries Ltd and BP Plc, has, however, moved rates at its pumps in tandem with PSUs.

After Saturday's increase, petrol at PSU pumps in Mumbai now costs Rs 108.49 per litre and diesel Rs 95.02, and Kolkata prices rose to Rs 110.64 and Rs 97.02, respectively. In Chennai, petrol is priced at Rs 105.31 and diesel at Rs 96.98.

Prices vary across states due to local taxes.

State-owned Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) together control 90 per cent of India's fuel market.

Opposition parties, however, accused the government of delaying price revisions until after key state elections.

The May 15 increase came after the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) expanded its electoral footprint by winning three of five state and UT elections, including West Bengal.

Despite the hikes, fuel retailers continue to absorb significant losses.

Petroleum Ministry's Joint Secretary Sujata Sharma had earlier this week stated that the May 15 increase reduced losses by about a fourth, but state-run oil firms were still losing around Rs 750 crore per day.

The Punjab Congress and the AAP slammed the BJP-led Centre over a third fuel price hike in just nine days, saying it has put yet another financial burden on ordinary citizens.

Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring slammed the Centre over the price hike, calling it the “real economics” of the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government.

“First create headlines with symbolic ‘simplicity’, then quietly transfer the burden to ordinary citizens through rising fuel prices. PM Modi showcases a ‘2-car convoy for cameras,” Warring said in a post on X.

He emphasised that when diesel prices rise, it leads to inflation across the entire economy, causing transport, vegetables, milk, farming, logistics, and daily essentials to become more expensive.

Aam Aadmi Party leader and MLA Kuldeep Singh Dhaliwal also criticised the BJP-led government for the latest fuel price hike, stating that he had previously predicted the government would once again raise fuel rates, and that prediction has now come true.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

IGI Airport

Concerted efforts were also being made to curb gold smuggling, he said.

Hydroponic weed is a high-potency form of cannabis cultivated in nutrient-rich water instead of soil.

According to an official statement, the two passengers landed in Delhi on May 22 and were intercepted after crossing the Green Channel at the airport.

“Acting on specific profiling inputs and suspicious travel indicators, Customs officers subjected the baggage of both passengers to detailed examination,” the statement said.

During a physical examination of the baggage, officials recovered six vacuum-sealed packets suspected to contain hydroponic weed.

Of the total seizure, four packets weighing around 29 kg were

recovered from one passenger, while two packets weighing around 19 kg were recovered from the second passenger, officials said.

“The total quantity of the suspected narcotic substance recovered in the case was approximately 47.805 kilograms (net weight),” the statement said.

According to Customs officials, the seized contraband has an estimated market value of around Rs 48 crore.

“This is one of the highest seizures in recent times at IGI airport, Delhi,” they said.

‘Rozgar Mela’

development journey,” he said.

In keeping with the prime minister's commitment to prioritising employment generation, the ‘Rozgar Mela’ is a major initiative aimed at translating this vision into reality, officials said.

The ‘Rozgar Mela’ was held at 47 locations across the country on Saturday.

The appointees, selected from all parts of India, will join various ministries and departments, including railways, home affairs, health and family welfare, and departments of financial services and higher education, among others.

Gymkhana Club

other vital public security purposes.

The government's move drew criticism from various quarters.

“Till now, it was the poor who were being affected, so the rich were not too bothered. Then came the turn of shopkeepers, so salaried professionals did not feel affected. Now it is the turn of senior officers and professionals who visit clubs. Everyone's turn will come eventually,” AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj said.

Madras Gymkhana Club president Capt S Seshadri said that it was a sad thing to happen to an institution of such stature. “I am not going to say it's fair or not fair. It's beyond my capacity to say that. But I feel sad,” he said.

Many members of the Delhi Gymkhana Club said that the order came as a “shock” to them, and they would challenge it in court. A member, on condition of anonymity, said that a government-appointed committee has been running the club for the last few years, and the current management is not expected to challenge the eviction order in the court of law. “How can we expect the current club management to challenge the order since it is currently being run by the government-appointed committee? Members will have to file an application on their own to challenge the government's order,” he said.

In its letter to the club's secretary, the L&DO said the leased land is essential to fulfil urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and public-interest projects, integrated with the resumption of adjoining government lands.

“In exercise of the powers conferred under Clause 4 of the Lease Deed, the President of India, through the Land & Development Office, hereby determines the lease and orders re-entry of the aforesaid premises with immediate effect,” it stated.

“Upon such re-entry, the entire plot of land measuring 27.3 acres,

along with all buildings, standing erections, structures, lawns, and fittings thereon, shall vest absolutely in the lessor, i.e., the President of India, through the Land & Development Office.”

According to the order, the premises will be taken over by the Land & Development Office on June 5.

“You are directed to hand over peaceful possession of the premises to the representatives of this office on the aforesaid date. In the event of non-compliance, possession shall be taken in accordance with law,” it stated.

A senior official in the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry said that most of the land allotted on lease to various institutions in Lutyens' Delhi is owned by the Government of India, which may invoke its “power” to take back its land, citing security and other reasons that are in the interest of the nation. The latest move comes against the backdrop of the recent removal of slums from the nearby Race Course Road.

In March this year, the Delhi High Court stayed the eviction notices issued to the Delhi Race Club at Kamal Ataturk Marg and the Jaipur Polo Ground in the Race Course area.

The court said that the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry cannot take “forcible possession” of these iconic premises.

The tussle between central authorities and the Delhi Gymkhana Club is not new.

In 2022, the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) permitted the Centre to take over the management of the prestigious Delhi Gymkhana Club, citing financial irregularities and violations of company law.

The tribunal authorised the Ministry of Corporate Affairs to replace the club's existing general committee with a government-appointed panel.

Another member of the club said that the Indira Gandhi Memorial, also located on Safdarjung Road, is visited by thousands of people every day, questioning how members of the club could be considered a “security hazard”.

Founded during the British era, the club began functioning from Civil Lines area in 1913 under the name Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club. It was renamed the Delhi Gymkhana Club after India gained Independence, while the existing structures were constructed in the 1930s. The present structure at Safdarjung

Road was built in the early 1930s, with architect Robert T Russell being entrusted with its design, according to the club's website.

Russell, also associated with Connaught Place and the Commanders-in-Chief's residence (later Teen Murti House), shaped the club as a prominent complex set amid large green lawns, according to historical accounts.

Meanwhile, uncertainty loomed over the fate of nearly 600 employees of the club following the government's eviction order as they have not yet received any formal briefing from the management.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

mother-in-law and former district judge Giribala Singh for alleged harassment for dowry.

Giribala Singh, who is currently the chairperson of the Bhopal District Consumer Court, on Saturday said she would be happy to record her statement, but Bho-

pal Police had not reached out to her so far.

She could not step out of her house owing to the chaotic situation outside, she said, apparently referring to the presence of mediapersons.

A day earlier, the High Court issued a notice to her on pleas seeking cancellation of her anticipatory bail, and sought her response by May 25. Two days ago, Bhopal Police had issued a third and final notice to her after she allegedly failed to appear for recording her statement.

The High Court on Friday also ordered a second autopsy for Twisha by a specialised team from the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Delhi, in response to a petition filed by her parents.

Accordingly, AIIMS Delhi constituted a medical board comprising four senior doctors to conduct a second autopsy. Chief of Forensic Medicine at AIIMS Delhi, Dr Sudhir Gupta, who set up the board, said it would fly to Bhopal by a state chartered plane at 6 pm.

Telangana

the next week, and the temperatures are likely to rise by 2 to 3 degrees Celsius from Sunday. In the last 24 hours, the weather remained largely dry across Rajasthan.

Delhi, too, remained trapped in intense summer conditions despite strong winds, thunderstorms, and light rain early morning, bringing temporary relief to parts of the city after days of searing heat.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) warned that temperatures across Delhi, Punjab, Haryana, and Chandigarh are likely to rise further from Sunday onwards. The heat's impact in the national capital has extended beyond humans.

Across the city, veterinarians and rescuers say that distress calls involving birds and stray animals suffering from dehydration, heat strokes, and infections have risen sharply over the past few weeks as prolonged dry conditions and extreme temperatures continue to batter Delhi and the NCR.

Delhi has been reeling under heatwave conditions over the past few days, with temperatures crossing the 45 degrees Celsius mark in several areas.

According to doctors, hospitals across Delhi-NCR are witnessing a rise in patients reporting heat-related ailments, including eye irritation, dehydration-induced headaches, and heat-triggered neurological symptoms.

In Punjab and Haryana, intense hot weather conditions prevailed. Rohtak in Haryana registered a maximum temperature at 44.1 degrees Celsius, while Punjab's Bathinda sizzled at 43.8 degrees Celsius. Among other places in Punjab, Amritsar recorded a high of 40.5 degrees Celsius, while Ludhiana's maximum was 41.2 degrees Celsius. Chandigarh, the common capital of the two states, recorded a high of 40.6 degrees Celsius.

In Haryana, Ambala's maximum was 41.2 degrees Celsius, while Hisar's maximum settled at 42.4 degrees Celsius.

Punjab Health Minister Dr Balbir Singh has directed the government hospitals to operationalise dedicated heat stroke management units with active cooling measures, including ice packs and cold IV fluids, and essential medical supplies.

Singh said that his depart-

ment has already taken proactive steps to prepare facilities and the workforce to prevent, mitigate, and manage the impacts of extreme heat. Essential medical supplies, such as ORS and emergency drugs, are well-stocked at every public health facility, he said in a statement.

The minister further noted that ambulance preparedness has been strengthened to provide pre-hospital cooling during transit.

In Himachal Pradesh, the Shimla meteorological centre has issued a yellow warning for heatwave conditions in parts of the state on May 26 and 27, with districts including Una, Bilaspur, Hamirpur, Kangra, Solan, and Sirmour likely to be affected. It also forecast a fresh wet spell and thunderstorms in several parts of the state over the next few days under the influence of a western disturbance.

In Jharkhand, the IMD issued a heatwave alert for the north-western districts of Garhwa, Palamu, and Chatra for Monday, while several other districts are likely to experience thunderstorms, lightning, and moderate rainfall over the next six days beginning May 24.

An orange alert has also been issued for rain in north-eastern and some central districts, especially Dhanbad, for Sunday.

In view of the prevailing heatwave-like conditions across the state, Chief Minister Hemant Soren, in a post on X, ordered all government officials and panchayat representatives to ensure proper arrangements for drinking water outside their offices and at public places for people.

In Uttar Pradesh, Congress leader and MP Kishori Lal Sharma wrote to Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath seeking immediate intervention regarding the deteriorating power supply situation in the Amethi parliamentary constituency amid heatwave conditions.

In his May 21 letter, Sharma said residents have been facing prolonged and unscheduled power cuts for several days during the intense summer heat, adversely affecting farmers, students, traders and the general public.

He said repeated outages were disrupting daily life, while irrigation activities in agricultural fields were also hit.

With heatwave conditions intensifying across several parts of the country, doctors are warning that prolonged exposure to high temperatures may adversely affect not only physical well-being but also eye and neurological functioning, especially among children, senior citizens and people with pre-existing medical conditions.

US, Iran

Esmail Baghaei as describing the draft as a “framework agreement” and adding: “We want this to include the main issues required for ending the imposed war and other issues of essential importance to us. Then, over a reasonable time span, between 30 and 60 days, details are discussed, and ultimately a final agreement is reached.”

He said the Strait of Hormuz is among the topics discussed.

Positions have moved closer in recent days, Iran's official IRNA news agency quoted Baghaei as saying.

“Over the past week, the trend has been toward narrowing differences,” he said. “We will have to wait and see what happens over the next three or four days.”

QUESTIONED GOVT ON OIL IMPORTS, INFLATION & STRATEGIC RESERVES

Govt ‘burdening’ common people with post-poll fuel price hike, alleges Cong

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Saturday accused the government of “burdening” the common people with a post-poll fuel price hike and also denying them the benefits of falling crude oil prices during the past decade.

Addressing a press conference, chairman of the Congress’s research department Rajeev Gowda questioned the government on oil imports, inflation and strategic reserves. “There is a race going on between fuel and the rupee as to which will hit the century first,” he said. He was accompanied by party leader Dolly Sharma at the press conference.

Referring to rising fuel prices, with petrol about to touch Rs 100 per litre, and the rapidly depreciating rupee, which was approaching 100 against the US dollar, Gowda



A worker fills fuel into a vehicle at a petrol pump, in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh, Saturday

repeatedly urged the government to reduce fuel and LPG prices.

He alleged that fuel price reductions were often timed around elections, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi being credited for them.

Referring to recent revisions in retail fuel prices, the Congress leader said that petrol prices in Delhi had risen by Rs 4.74 per litre between May 14 and May 23, 2026, while diesel prices had increased by a similar amount during the same period.

The party warned that rising petrol and diesel prices would sharply increase transportation costs and trigger inflation in essential commodities such as vegetables, fruits, milk and household goods.

It also cited recent milk price hikes by Amul and Mother Dairy as early signs of inflationary pressure.

Highlights

» ‘There is a race going on between fuel and the rupee as to which will hit the century first’

» Congress leaders said that at peak of fuel price increases in October 2021, taxes constituted around 54 per cent of petrol prices and 49 per cent of diesel prices in Delhi

PTI

said when global crude prices collapsed from 2014, the Centre retained high excise duties and kept retail fuel prices elevated instead of reducing prices for consumers.

The Congress leaders said that at the peak of fuel price increases in October 2021, taxes constituted around 54 per cent of petrol prices and 49 per cent of diesel prices in Delhi.

They added that despite India importing discounted Russian crude oil after the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022, the government did not adequately pass on the benefits to consumers.

They referred to the wind-fall tax imposed in July 2022, saying the government had collected around Rs 25,000 crore in 2022-23 from wind-

fall prof There is a race going on between fuel and the rupee as to which will hit the century first its even as private refiners continued to benefit from export margins. Gowda said that oil marketing companies later posted significant profits.

He said that inflation remained persistently high during the same period and asserted that the Congress had

TN: 10-yr-old girl sexually assaulted & killed, 2 held

OUR CORRESPONDENT

COIMBATORE/CHENNAI: A 10-year-old girl was sexually assaulted and brutally killed in Coimbatore, leading to shock and outrage across Tamil Nadu, and Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Saturday promised strict action following opposition uproar.

A 33-year old man, who allegedly committed sexual assault has been arrested under POCSO and for other offences including murder and his accomplice has been nabbed for criminal conspiracy, police said.

Terming the incident as “horrific,” CM Vijay said such inhuman and unforgivable criminal acts can never be

tolerated.

“I share my deepest condolences with the family of the girl,” he said in a statement.

Referring to the arrest of the two persons, he said the Tamil Nadu government will act firmly to ensure that those who engage in such heinous acts against women and children receive severe punishment under the law. “All immediate and necessary actions for this will be taken,” he asserted.

Opposition leaders -- DMK’s Udhayanidhi Stalin, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami, AMMK chief TTV Dhinakaran and PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss strongly condemned the crime and demanded tough action.

Centre notifies draft rules for VB-G RAM G rollout, outlines transition from MGNREGA

Closer Look

» Officials in the Ministry of Rural Development said the rules are aimed at establishing the institutional, financial and governance framework for implementation of the Act across the country

» The rules provide for continuation of ongoing works, settlement of liabilities, transfer of records and continuation of worker rights during the transition period

The proposed rules cover transitional provisions, the National Level Steering Committee, the Central Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Council, administrative expenses, grievance redressal, payment of wages and unemployment allowance, and expenditure incurred beyond normative allocations, including for Union

Territories without legislatures. Officials in the Ministry of Rural Development said the rules are aimed at establishing the institutional, financial and governance framework for implementation of the Act across the country and ensuring participatory consultation before the rules are finalised. The draft Transitional Pro-

visions Rules spell out the framework for shifting from MGNREGA to VB-G RAM G, which was notified on May 11 and is scheduled to come into force across states and Union Territories from July 1.

The rules provide for continuation of ongoing works, settlement of liabilities, transfer of records and continuation of worker rights during the transition period.

Existing e-KYC-verified MGNREGA job cards will remain temporarily valid until new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards are issued, while fresh works may also be opened if ongoing projects are insufficient to meet labour demand.

MPOST

Truth about BJP’s health services exposed before HC: Hooda

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition, Bhupinder Singh Hooda has stated that the BJP government is continuously playing with the lives of the people of the state and the Punjab and Haryana High Court itself has held up a mirror to the government,

expressing deep concern over the dilapidated state of health services.

Making scathing remarks regarding Haryana’s health-care system, Hooda said the Court explicitly pointed out that there is a severe shortage of doctors in the state.

“Hundreds of posts for Medical Officers and spe-

cialist doctors have remained vacant for years, yet the government shows no interest in filling them. Even basic amenities are unavailable in district hospitals. The court was compelled to mandate that every district hospital must compulsorily be equipped with at least one CT scan machine, one MRI machine, and an ICU facility,” he said.

Haryana CM asks CMGGAs to focus on citizen-centric governance

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Saturday directed officer and Chief Minister’s Good Governance Associates (CMGGAs) to intensify efforts towards effective implementation of public welfare schemes and swift resolution of people’s grievances at the grassroots level.

Chairing a high-level review meeting at Sant Kabir Kutir with CMGGAs, the Chief Minister said the true measure of governance lies in how efficiently government services and welfare benefits reach the last person in society. Calling for greater sensitivity and responsiveness in administration, he



asserted that even the smallest issue faced by citizens should be treated with seriousness and resolved in a time-bound manner.

CM urged CMGGAs to serve as a strong bridge between the government and the people by providing real-time grassroots feedback and helping strengthen policy execution across sectors.

He asserted that even the smallest grievance of citizens must be addressed with sensi-

tivity and urgency.

Meanwhile, chairing a review meeting of the Irrigation and Water Resources Department’s five-year action plan, CM Saini said that state govt is committed to ensuring adequate irrigation water reaches every field. For this purpose, the Irrigation Department should form farmer groups and construct community tanks for every 10 acres or more of agricultural land.

These tanks will be filled with canal water, and irrigation will be carried out through micro-irrigation systems. The Government will provide 85 per cent subsidy for the construction of such tanks, said Nayab Singh Saini.

Libraries to be set up in all 395 Gram Panchayats: Khattar

Union minister tours several villages in Nilokheri Assembly constituency, interacts with public in Haryana

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Union Minister for Power and Urban Development, Manohar Lal Khattar said that this is the era of education and learning, and education is essential for the younger generation.

To strengthen educational opportunities along with school education and to provide coaching-like facilities within villages, libraries will be established in all 395 Gram Panchayats of Karnal district so that youth can access facilities for competitive exam preparation at the village level itself.

During his scheduled visit on Saturday, the Union Minister toured several villages in Nilokheri Assembly constituency where he directly interacted with the public and addressed their grievances. He will also visit villages in Assandh Assembly constituency on Sunday.

The Union minister said that in Haryana jobs are being provided to educated youth on the

Key Points

» ‘In Haryana jobs are being provided to educated youth on the basis of merit, whereas in earlier govts, jobs were given to favourites through recommendations and monetary influence’

» Khattar also highlighted that under the Mhara Gaon-Jagmag Gaon scheme

to provide coaching-like facilities to rural youth within their own villages, the decision has been taken to open libraries in all Gram Panchayats.

Along with this, priorities also include construction of boundary walls and sheds in cremation grounds, development of pucca roads, and ensuring proper drinking water supply in villages.

Khattar also highlighted that under the Mhara Gaon-Jagmag Gaon scheme, 24-hour electricity supply is being ensured in the state, whereas earlier there used to be power shortages and people were forced to protest by blocking roads.

He said that on May 21, the highest-ever electricity supply in the country was recorded, with uninterrupted supply of 270.80 gigawatts against demand.

Currently, the country has an availability of 283 gigawatts, and preparations are being made to handle up to 300 gigawatts in the future. A decade ago, even meeting a demand of 250 gigawatts was not possible.

Ladakh: Centre offers constitutional safeguards and legislative body

Talks are still underway, say activists from region

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Sonam calls himself ‘honorary cockroach’

NEW DELHI: Environmentalist and educationist Sonam Wangchuk on Saturday voiced support for the online “cockroach” movement led by the self-styled “Cockroach Janata Party” (CJP), describing himself as an “honorary cockroach”, as he urged the govt to engage with the concerns being raised by youngsters rather than suppressing their digital expression.

The online campaign,

which uses satire and the imagery of a cockroach as a symbol of resilience and dissent, has drawn attention in recent days amid claims by its founders of a crackdown on their social-media presence, including account suspensions and hacking allegations. The movement has framed itself around issues, such as unemployment, exam paper leaks and public accountability.

MPOST

trative and financial powers for Ladakh and had been asked to share a formal draft for consultations with legal and constitutional experts.

The meeting between representatives of the Leh Apex Body (LAB), KDA and the MHA sub-committee on Friday focused on constitutional protection for Ladakh, democratic representation and the long-pending demand

for statehood.

According to Wangchuk, the discussions centred on Ladakh’s demand for inclusion under the Sixth Schedule and statehood, while the government suggested safeguards under Article 371.

“The government said it has some issues with the Sixth Schedule but is willing to consider protections under Article 371,” Wangchuk said.

CDS: Future wars will be multi-domain with cyber and cognitive aspects

OUR CORRESPONDENT



CDS Gen Anil Chauhan

SHIRDI: Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan on Saturday said future wars will be multi-domain with land, sea, air, cyberspace, and cognitive warfare operating together, with technology, speed and innovation being important determinants of successful operations.

Speaking at the inauguration of a defence manufacturing unit here in Maharashtra’s Ahilyanagar district, General Chauhan said war, warfare and methods of war are witnessing rapid changes.

Asserting that modern warfare is not just based on manpower, conventional weapons or platform-centric operations, the top military officer said AI, drones, robotics, cyber systems, autonomous platforms, space technologies, precision strike weapons, and information dominance are giving a decisive shape to future wars.

In the coming days, technology, speed and innovation will be important determinants of successful operations, he said.

“Future wars will be multi-

domain where land, sea, cyberspace, cognitive warfare, and air will operate together. Battlefields will not be limited to geographical space, but to information networks, digital ecosystems and cyber infrastructure,” the CDS said.

In such a scenario, national security is not just dependent on the courage of soldiers, sailors and air warriors but also on technological ecosystem, industrial capability, manufacturing strength and innovation capacity, Chauhan said.

Any country that innovates, speeds up production and whose armed forces adapt fast will have strategic advantage, the CDS added.

एनटीपीसी NTPC NTPC Limited (A Govt. of India Enterprise)									
Extract of the Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended 31 March 2026									
Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
		Quarter ended 31.03.2026 (Audited) #	Quarter ended 31.03.2025 (Audited) #	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Year ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)	Quarter ended 31.03.2026 (Audited) #	Quarter ended 31.03.2025 (Audited) #	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Year ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1	Total income from operations	43110.74	43903.65	165493.74	170037.37	49687.77	49833.70	187384.63	188138.06
2	Net profit before tax (before exceptional items)	6704.73	6034.24	22556.93	23636.40	8366.38	8326.80	27133.56	28496.41
3	Net profit before tax (after exceptional items)	6704.73	6034.24	22556.93	23636.40	8366.38	8326.80	27133.56	28496.41
4	Profit after tax	8747.27	5778.14	23162.22	19649.41	10614.95	7897.14	27545.76	23953.15
5	Profit after tax attributable to owners of the parent company					10486.47	7611.22	27052.52	23422.46
6	Profit after tax attributable to non-controlling interest					128.48	285.92	493.24	530.69
7	Total comprehensive income after tax	8747.23	5723.89	23003.23	19461.10	10733.12	7805.20	27587.32	23622.81
8	Paid-up equity share capital (Face value of share ₹ 10/- each)	9696.67	9696.67	9696.67	9696.67	9696.67	9696.67	9696.67	9696.67
9	Other equity excluding revaluation reserve as per balance sheet	165168.58	151943.88	165168.58	151943.88	193479.00	174374.49	193479.00	174374.49
10	Net worth*	174688.19	160259.96	174688.19	160259.96	203023.74	182881.09	203023.74	182881.09
11	Paid up debt capital	190109.58	185243.57	190109.58	185243.57	267258.20	247575.12	267258.20	247575.12
12	Debenture redemption reserve	1587.81	1857.74	1587.81	1857.74	2705.61	2871.12	2705.61	2871.12
13	Earnings per equity share (of ₹ 10/- each)-(not annualised) (including net movement in regulatory deferral account balances): Basic and Diluted (in ₹)	9.02	5.96	23.89	20.26	10.81	7.85	27.90	24.16
14	Earnings per equity share (of ₹ 10/- each)-(not annualised) (excluding net movement in regulatory deferral account balances): Basic and Diluted (in ₹)	15.93	3.83	26.88	16.85	17.84	5.48	30.44	20.34

* Excluding Fly ash utilization reserve and items of Other comprehensive income.

Figures of last quarter are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of the full financial year and the published year to date figures upto the third quarter of the current/previous financial year.

Notes:

1. The above is an extract of the financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges in compliance with Regulations 33 and 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended. The complete financial results are accessible on the Company’s website at following link <https://www.ntpc.co.in/investors/financial-performance/financial-results> and in the Corporate Section of BSE Limited (<https://www.bseindia.com>) and National Stock Exchange of India Limited (<https://www.nseindia.com>). They can also be accessed by scanning the Quick Response Code given below.

2. Previous periods figures have been reclassified wherever considered necessary.

Place: New Delhi
Date: 23.05.2026

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For and on behalf of Board of Directors of

NTPC Limited

Sd/-

(Jaikumar Srinivasan)

Director (Finance)

DIN:01220828

Trump to decide by Sunday on resuming war with Iran

Trump said it was a ‘solid 50/50’ as to whether he would be able to make a ‘good’ deal or ‘blow them to kingdom come’

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Saturday said he was meeting with his negotiators to discuss Iran's latest offer and would likely decide by Sunday whether to resume the war, US media outlet Axios reported.

Trump told Axios that it was a “solid 50/50” as to whether he would be able to make a “good” deal or else “blow them to kingdom come.” The US President said he would meet with special envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner to discuss the proposal from Tehran. Vice President JD Vance, who is in Ohio, is likely to return to Washington to join the meeting.



US President Donald Trump

Pakistan's Army chief Asim Munir was in Tehran to discuss with the negotiators on the fine print of the peace deal.

In Delhi, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said, “There’s been some progress done, some progress made. Even as I speak to you now, there’s some work being done. There is a chance that, whether it’s later today, tomorrow (Sunday), in a couple of days, we may have some-

thing to say.”

Rubio, who is on a four-day visit to India, said the President has said one way or the other, Iran can never have a nuclear weapon, the Strait needs to be open without tolls, and Tehran needs to turn over its highly enriched uranium.

Trump told Axios that he would only take a deal that covers issues like uranium enrichment and the fate of Iran’s

existing stockpile.

The US and Iran are negotiating a letter of intent to end the war and commit to 30 days of more in-depth negotiations, Axios reported.

“I think one of two things will happen: either I hit them harder than they have ever been hit, or we are going to sign a deal that is good,” Trump said. He acknowledged that “some people would much rather have

Highlights

- » Trump said he would meet with special envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner to discuss proposal from Tehran
- » Vice President J D Vance, who is in Ohio, is likely to return to Washington to join the meeting
- » Pakistan’s Army chief Asim Munir was in Tehran to discuss nfine print of peace deal

a deal and others would rather resume the war,” but rejected the idea that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu was “worried” that he might make an unfavourable deal.

A source close to Trump and a second source with knowledge of the situation told Axios that Trump had grown increasingly frustrated about the negotiations with Iran over the past several days.

Coal mine gas explosion in north China’s Shanxi Province kills 90

Around 123 people of those rescued are receiving treatment at hospitals, including two in critical condition and two in serious condition

BEIJING: Ninety miners were killed in a gas explosion in a coal mine in north China's Shanxi Province, while all-out rescues are underway to reach those still unaccounted for, official media in Beijing reported on Saturday.

A total of 247 workers were underground when the accident occurred on Friday evening at the Liushenyu coal mine in Qinyuan County, Changzhi.

Mining disasters are common in energy-hungry China, and are largely attributed to poor working conditions and a weak regulatory framework.



In this photo released by Xinhua News Agency, rescue workers pass by an ambulance in the aftermath of an explosion at Changzhi city’s Liushenyu coal mine in Shanxi Province on Saturday

The death toll rose to 90 following the accident, while around 123 people of those rescued are receiving treatment at hospitals, including two in critical condition and two in serious condition. Nine people remain unaccounted for as rescue operations continue to locate them, state-run media reported.

“As long as there is hope, we will make every possible effort,” one rescuer told Xinhua.

Chinese President Xi Jinping has issued instructions for a comprehensive rescue operation and treatment of the injured. He has called for

proper handling of the aftermath of the accident and sought a thorough investigation into its cause, with accountability pursued in accordance with the law.

Xi has stressed that authorities across the country must learn from the accident, remain vigilant on workplace safety, and intensify efforts to identify and eliminate potential risks to prevent major accidents.

As China enters its flood season, Xi also called for

strengthened emergency preparedness and solid flood control and disaster relief measures to safeguard people’s lives and property. Vice Premier Zhang Guoqing has led a team to the site to oversee the rescue efforts.

While such incidents take place almost every year, the worst mining disaster was in 2005, resulting in the death of 214 people, following a gas explosion at the Sunjiawan coal mine in Liaoning province in China’s northeast. Here are some major incidents:

- 2023: 53 people were killed after a collapse at an open-pit mine in northern China’s Inner Mongolia region.
- 2009: 108 miners died as a result of a gas explosion at the state-run Xinxing mine in Heilongjiang province near the border with Russia. State broadcaster CCTV displayed a diagram showing the miners trapped about a third of a mile underground. Footage showed that one entrance was blocked, and rescuers in orange suits with breathing equipment were attempting to enter through another.
- 2005: 171 people died in a blast at the Dongfeng coal mine in Qitaihe in Heilongjiang province.
- 2004: 148 people were killed in a gas explosion at the Daping coal mine in China’s inland Henan province.
- 2000: 162 people died after an explosion at the mountain-gou coal mine in the mountainous Guizhou province in China’s southwest.

India’s Major Abhilasha Barak to receive UN Military Gender Advocate Award

UNITED NATIONS: Indian peacekeeper serving with the UN mission in Lebanon, Major Abhilasha Barak, has been named the recipient of a prestigious military gender advocate award by the world body.

Barak has been honoured with the 2025 United Nations Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award for her outreach efforts with women and

girls during her deployment in the West Asian nation.

“Proud to announce that Major Abhilasha Barak has been awarded the 2025 @UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award,” the Permanent Mission of India to the UN said in a post on X on Friday.

Barak is serving with the Indian Battalion as the Com-

mander of the Female Engagement Team (FET) in UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL). She is also the first woman combat helicopter pilot of the Indian Army.

She will be honoured at the UN headquarters when the world body commemorates the International Day of UN Peacekeepers that is marked annually on May 29.

China to send 1st astronaut from Hong Kong to space mission

BEIJING: China plans to launch its next manned mission to the Tiangong space station on Sunday — the country’s first space mission to have a Hong Kong astronaut onboard.

Chinese astronauts Zhu Yangzhu and Zhang Zhiyuan, and Hong Kong’s Li Jiaying will be part of the Shenzhou-23 crewed spaceflight mission, said China Manned Space Agency on Saturday.

Li Jiaying is the first orbital

traveller from Hong Kong.

This development comes years after Hong Kong was handed back to China by the UK on July 1, 1997, with certain rights supposed to be guaranteed for at least 50 years under the “one country, two systems” agreement.

The Shenzhou-23 crewed spaceship is scheduled to be launched at 11:08 pm on Sunday (Beijing Time) from the Jiuquan Satellite Launch Centre

in northwest China, said Zhang Jingbo, CMSA.

China replaces the crew of its station in low orbit every six months, but this time, one of the new crew members may stay for a year to study the long-term effects on the astronaut’s health and to improve in-orbit medical support, the spokesperson said.

The crew of the current Shenzhou spaceship has so far been aloft for more than 200

days and is on track to break the record held by the previous crew, which returned to Earth after 204 days.

During their time on the space station, the Shenzhou-23 crew will conduct more than 100 new scientific studies, including research on zebrafish, mice and artificial embryos to study reproduction in space.

After the Hong Kong astronaut, China plans to send a

Pakistani national to the station. Two selected candidates from Pakistan are currently undergoing training.

Earlier this month, Chinese space officials said plans are afoot to expand the low-earth orbiting space station, potentially more than doubling in size as the rival International Space Station (ISS) is set to be phased out by 2031.

China operationalised its space station in 2022.

Sport

The return of the King

Ton-up Shreyas keeps Punjab Kings’ playoff hopes flickering

LUCKNOW: Punjab Kings rediscovered their winning touch after six defeats in a row through skipper Shreyas Iyer’s majestic unbeaten 101 as they handed Lucknow Super Giants a seven-wicket towelling to stay alive in the IPL playoffs race here on Saturday.

Shreyas, whose maiden IPL hundred came off 51 balls, and Prabhsimran Singh (69, 39 balls) added 140 runs for the third wicket as Punjab chased LSG’s 196/2 in 18 overs. PBKS made 200/3.

The victory helped Punjab to reach 15 points from their all 14 league engagements to reclaim the No. 4 position on the table.

But now, they will have to go through an excruciating wait to know their fate as Rajasthan Royals (14) are taking on Mumbai Indians on Sunday at Mumbai.

If RR win the match then, Punjab will enter the playoffs as the fourth placed team with 16 points. The Kolkata Knight Riders (13 points), who are up against Delhi Capitals in the weekend’s second clash, too have an outside chance should RR fail to go past MI.

In that case, it will be a battle of net run rate between KKR and PBKS, with both tied on 15 points. Royal Challengers Ben-



Shreyas Iyer scored an unbeaten 101, his maiden IPL hundred

galuru, Sunrisers Hyderabad and Gujarat Titans are already in the knockouts.

But the equation worries are for another time, as Shreyas showed his steely nerves while chasing yet again with a fabu-

lous knock.

Opener Priyansh Arya fell to a first-ball duck to Mohammad Shami (2/45) and the veteran India pacer uprooted Cooper Connolly’s off-stump as PBKS plunged into turmoil.

But Shreyas was least bothered about those early impediments, and as expected, lorded over spinners and pacers alike with drives, pulls and those trademark flicks off pads.

He was severe on spinners Digvesh Rathee, scorching him for a flurry of onside boundaries, and Prabshimran, who got reprieves on 20 and 62, backed his leader with aplomb.

Prabshimran reached his sixth fifty of the season off 26 balls while his senior partner reached that mark in 33 balls.

Once crossed fifty, Shreyas wore the cape of an enforcer, and the next 51 runs came off just 18 balls. The dismissal of Prabshimran, who fell leg before to left-arm pacer Arjun Tendulkar, was a minor aberration as Punjab reached him with ease.

Shreyas, who reached his hundred with a six off Mohsin Khan that also signalled PBKS’ win, also pummeled Shami for three sixes in an over to speed his side to victory march.

Earlier, Josh Inglis made a typically punishing 72, guiding LSG to a handy 196 for six.

Inglis and Pant (26, 21b) added 65 runs for the fourth wicket as the already-eliminated LSG recovered from a shaky 69 for three in the seventh over.

Could have been in top-four: Bell

KOLKATA: Delhi Capitals assistant coach Ian Bell on Saturday said his side has been left frustrated by the “small margins” that separated them from a “top-two” finish after an inconsistent campaign marked by dramatic highs and lows.

Delhi will face Kolkata Knight Riders in the final league match of the season on Sunday, though their slim playoff hopes could already be extinguished depending on results elsewhere.

“Most teams outside the top four will probably say the same thing -- consistency,” Bell said. “We’ve shown this season that we can score 265 (264/2) and then follow it up by getting bowled out for 70 (75). We scored 265 (264/2) and still couldn’t defend it. There were times when we were brilliant, and there were times when we simply weren’t good enough.”

MUMBAI: Rajasthan Royals would look to go full throttle in their bid to seal the last Indian Premier League playoffs spot when they take on a struggling Mumbai Indians here on Sunday.

It will be a test of resilience and fitness for both the teams on a potentially hot and humid Sunday afternoon here, as Mumbai Indians would be determined to sign off with a consolation win, while Rajasthan Royals would be aware that a defeat would take their fate out of their hands.

The Royals -- currently placed fourth with 14 points -- need to win against Mumbai Indians, which will take them to 16 points, at least one point clear of both Punjab Kings and Kolkata Knight Riders, who are still in the fray.

But if RR lose on Sunday, they will hope for both Punjab and Knight Riders to also suffer defeats in their final matches for the Jaipur-based side to have any chance of making the play-offs. The Royals have lost more than they have won in their last five outings, but they will fancy their chances of a win against MI, knowing the conditions of the venue which has small dimensions.

Sooryavanshi factor

For someone who is on the



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is six maximums away from history

“He practices hard and then when he goes out to play, he just enjoys himself”

— Trevor Penney, RR’s assistant coach

year’s IPL so far and is only six hits away from breaking Gayle’s record of 59 sixes in an edition.

“(Sooryavanshi’s) running between the wickets, (is) very good. But he doesn’t really have to run between the wickets too much, does he? It’s just about to break Chris Gayle’s record for sixes,” Penney said.

Penney said there are no doubts about Sooryavanshi’s skills on the field and in order to keep him fresh for batting, he has been kept out of fielding work during matches. “He is a very good fielder. He has got great hands. He moves well, he dives, he anticipates, he has got all that. It’s just the way it has worked out and sometimes with him opening the batting, him going in and (in) the second innings being fresh.”

Fed Cup: Gurindervir blurs to NR, Tejaswin shines

RANCHI: Gurindervir Singh ran a sensational race to lower the men’s 100m national record time to 10.09 seconds, Vishal TK became the first Indian to run 400m below 45 seconds and decathlete Tejaswin Shankar emerged as the first from the country to accumulate 8000 points on a historic second day of the National Senior Federation Competition here on Saturday.

Gurindervir clocked Asia’s second fastest time this season, while Vishal did even better as his 44.98 seconds effort is the

continent’s best so far this year.

In yet another astounding achievement, Asian Games silver medallist Tejaswin became the first Indian to cross the 8000 point mark in the Decathlon, smashing his own national record. His points tally now places him number seven on the Asian all time list.

Representing Reliance Foundation, the 27-year-old Tejaswin accumulated 8057 points in the gruelling 10-event discipline to better his own national record of 7947 set last year.

Sinner is the man to beat at French Open

PARIS: With defending champion Carlos Alcaraz out injured and Novak Djokovic undercooked on clay, the big question heading into the French Open is can anyone stop Jannik Sinner from securing the career Grand Slam in Paris?

Sinner’s season began to build momentum through a “Sunshine Double” of titles at Indian Wells and Miami before the Italian took complete control of the European clay swing with triumphs in Monte Carlo, Madrid and Rome.

The 24-year-old Italian has a golden opportunity to capture the only major title missing



Jannik Sinner is the favourite to win the French Open

from his collection 12 months after a heartbreaking loss to Alcaraz in the final.

Central to Sinner’s rise has

been his growing authority on the sport’s slowest surface.

“This year is the first time I’ve won something big on clay,”

he said in Rome of his Monaco win. “Also physically I’m getting stronger. It’s a mix of everything. That experience, to play certain points in a better way, but mostly I feel like physically if you improve, it helps you a lot on clay.”

Victory at Roland Garros would bring Sinner a fifth major and complete the set a few months after Alcaraz did so at the Australian Open. With Alcaraz skipping his Paris title defence due to a wrist injury, Djokovic looms as one of the few with the game to test Sinner. He will resume his hunt for a record 25th Slam title.

Praggnanandhaa holds Giri; Keymer wins title

BUCHAREST: Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa ended his campaign with an easy draw against Anish Giri while Vincent Keymer crushed Jordan Van Foreest to clinch the Super Chess Classic title here on Saturday.

Getting into the final round in joint lead with Fabiano Caruana of United States on five points, Keymer had an excellent chance to annex the crown if he wins against Dutchman Foreest.

Keymer ended the tournament on six points from four

victories, four draws and a lone loss against Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan.

Caruana finished second after a draw with Vachier-Lagrave finishing with a tally of 5.5 points.

Wesley So of the US played an easy draw with Sindarov in the finale to end joint third with the Uzbek on five points and it was a five-way tie thereafter with Praggnanandhaa, Giri, Foreest, Vachier-Lagrave and Deac Bogdan-Daniel of Romania ending on an identical 4.5 points.



India Between BRICS And The West

AS BRICS EXPANDS AMID RISING GEOPOLITICAL TENSIONS, INDIA FINDS ITSELF NAVIGATING AN INCREASINGLY FRAGILE BALANCE BETWEEN STRATEGIC AUTONOMY, WESTERN PARTNERSHIPS, AND THE AMBITIONS OF AN EVOLVING GLOBAL SOUTH BLOC

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

On the landmark occasion of the 20th anniversary of BRICS, which was formalised at the first meeting of BRIC Foreign Ministers on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in New York in 2006, the BRICS Ministers of Foreign Affairs/International Relations met on 14 and 15 May 2026 in New Delhi. Currently, BRICS serves as a useful platform for consultation and cooperation on contemporary issues for eleven major emerging markets and developing countries of the world: Brazil, China, Egypt, Ethiopia, India, Indonesia, Iran, Russia, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, and the United Arab Emirates. India assumed the BRICS Presidency on 1 January 2026 and, as the current Chair, will host the 18th BRICS Summit on September 12–13 this year.

The recently concluded BRICS Foreign Ministers' meeting in Delhi failed to issue a joint statement, leaving host India to release only a Chair's Statement that exposed major differences among member states. Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi skipped the BRICS Foreign Ministers' meeting held in New Delhi, citing scheduling conflicts. He remained in Beijing to meet U.S. President Donald Trump, who was visiting China at the same time. China was represented at the Delhi summit by its Ambassador to India, Xu Feihong.

At the BRICS October 2024 summit in Kazan, Russia, the original five members of the BRICS coalition — Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa — welcomed four new members into their fold: Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE). In January 2025, Indonesia became the bloc's tenth member. Although Saudi Arabia has not officially become a full member, it was invited to join BRICS+ at the 15th BRICS Summit, held in South Africa in 2023. Its status remains ambiguous.

Saudi Arabia and the UAE have their own brand of ambition in using the BRICS platform. Flush with oil wealth, they are like the cousins who arrived late to the party but showed up in luxury cars. Saudi Arabia, trying to rebrand itself from a "strict kingdom of repression" into a modern powerhouse, still carries an image problem — thanks to its less-than-stellar human rights record. Meanwhile, the UAE is the flashy one — hosting world expos, building futuristic cities, and collecting islands like they are toy pieces. But behind the glamour, both countries are still navigating their way through authoritarian systems disguised



as progress. Nevertheless, none of the BRICS members, including India, can fully claim to be liberal democratic states.

BRICS AT A CROSSROADS

BRICS already accounts for about 49.5 per cent of the global population, 40 per cent of world GDP, 26 per cent of global trade, and produces 30 per cent of the world's oil. In addition to its dedicated institutions, such as the Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA), created in 2014 with initial funding of USD 100 billion, and the New Development Bank (NDB), established in 2015 with an initial subscribed capitalisation of USD 50 billion, the coalition has embraced networked multilateralism, launching transnational partnerships and working groups on issues ranging from energy security to health, climate change, sustainable development, and technology transfer. However, some analysts anticipate that BRICS could evolve into a coherent anti-Western bloc and complicate prospects for multilateralism by deepening divisions within the G20 and the United Nations.

India assumed the BRICS chair at a time when the grouping is at a crucial juncture due to an imbalance in geo-economics. The USA's hegemony over the global economy is eroding rapidly. Though the Delhi meet, held during the ongoing war in Iran, was the first geopolitical stress test of an expanded BRICS, it failed to produce a joint communiqué as tensions between new entrants Iran and the UAE reportedly derailed consensus after Tehran accused the UAE of facilitating US-Israeli military operations, while the UAE accused Iran of violating its sovereignty.

As an alternative to the joint communiqué, the "New Delhi Chair's Statement" focused on areas where consensus remained possible, notably de-escalation in West Asia, opposition to unilateral sanctions, reform of the UN system, climate finance, development of the Global South, and institutional management of BRICS expansion. But what the statement did not say is equally significant. The text avoided anti-West bloc discourse, military alignment language, explicit condemnation of Israel

or the US, endorsement of Iran's military position, or aggressive de-dollarisation rhetoric.

Among analysts, the significance of the BRICS expansion remains a matter of debate. BRICS admittedly seeks to challenge Western-dominated institutions of global economic governance, as well as displace the U.S. dollar from its entrenched role in the world economy. Several analysts, therefore, depict BRICS expansion as a watershed moment in the shift toward a more egalitarian international system.

In 2025, BRICS shelved the idea of a common currency during its summit in Brazil. India's Foreign Minister stated that there is "no policy on our part to replace the dollar." The 2026 project — the creation of payment infrastructure BRICS Pay, linking Russia's SPFS, China's CIPS, India's UPI, and Brazil's Pix — is targeted for operational deployment at the September 12–13 New Delhi summit. mBridge, the multi-central-bank digital currency platform built with the Bank for International Settlements, had already processed over 4,000

transactions worth USD 55.49 billion by November 2025.

Though most countries engaged with BRICS are united in their desire to shift the global balance of power away from American unipolarity, several BRICS member states, partner countries, and aspirants remain divided over their engagement with the United States, and particularly over the extent to which BRICS is, or should become, an explicitly anti-American bloc designed to counter U.S. interests. Countries like India and the UAE seek to maintain positive relations with the United States even as they welcome the emergence of a more egalitarian world order.

During the May 2026 BRICS Foreign Ministers' summit in New Delhi, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi urged BRICS to directly condemn the US and Israel for "unlawful aggression". India, however, did not join Iran in condemning the United States. Conversely, the UAE pushed for

language explicitly condemning Iran. Unable to bridge the divide, India released a "Chair's Statement and Outcome Document" instead of a consensus-driven joint declaration.

The bloc is structurally divided. While China favours yuan internationalisation, India prefers its own digital rupee and resists binding agreements. India's parallel membership in the Quad limits any China-Russia axis. Bloomberg reports that the BRICS-led Development Bank is increasingly promoting yuan funding for the Global South.

INDIA'S COMPLEX ENGAGEMENT WITH BRICS

A week before the BRICS Summit in South Africa in 2023, the South China Morning Post wrote: "India may soon be forced to choose between BRICS and the West." Presently, India finds itself at the crossroads of geopolitics.

India's "foot in more than one boat", balancing relationships with the G7-led Western bloc, may isolate New Delhi at the forthcoming BRICS Summit. Some analysts argue that India's pro-USA policies are distancing it from the "China-centric" BRICS bloc. BRICS minus India (and the UAE) would fundamentally transform the grouping from an emerging market-driven economic alliance into a more overtly anti-Western political bloc.

India is set to host a meeting of Quad foreign ministers on May 26, which is expected to deliberate on pressing global challenges, including the fallout of the West Asia crisis and the prevailing situation in the Indo-Pacific. The Quad, comprising India, the US, Australia, and Japan, has emerged as a key grouping focused largely on peace, security, and stability in the Indo-Pacific region. India is hosting the meeting in its capacity as the current Chair of the coalition.

It may be recalled that during his first term, U.S. President Donald Trump quietly revived the grouping, originally created at Japan's initiative in 2007, after a nearly decade-long hiatus. Yet,

since his return to the White House in 2025, Trump has refused to participate, leaving the Quad leaderless and diminishing its geostrategic value. In 2025, the scheduled Quad Summit in Delhi was not held. The last Quad summit took place in Wilmington in 2024.

The forthcoming Quad meeting on May 26 will be attended by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, and Japanese Foreign Minister Motegi Toshimitsu, with Indian External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar presiding over it. It is reported that, besides deliberating on pressing global challenges, including the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia, the foreign ministers are expected to review cooperation in the Indo-Pacific, a region witnessing increasing Chinese assertiveness.

In a video message shared on X by the U.S. Embassy in India, Mr. Rubio said: "As America gets ready to celebrate our 250th birthday, we look forward to doing it with our partners in India. India is the world's largest democracy and we are the world's oldest. So, we look forward to celebrating it together."

Ahead of his first official visit to India as US Secretary of State, Marco Rubio underscored Washington's intention to deepen energy cooperation with New Delhi, calling India a "great ally and partner" of the United States. Rubio stated that Washington wants US energy to become a larger component of India's export basket. He also pointed to potential opportunities involving Venezuelan oil supplies for India.

Rubio's Kolkata visit carries additional significance following US President Donald Trump's congratulations to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on what the White House described as a historic and decisive election victory in West Bengal, where the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) secured a breakthrough win.

Before the BRICS Summit in September, the 52nd G7 Summit will be held in France from June 15 to 17, 2026. French President Emmanuel Macron has invited Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the G7 Summit. India's stance at the Quad and G7 summits will be closely watched by BRICS members.

Though India's trade engagement with BRICS nations has grown strongly over the past five years, and India's bilateral trade with the other ten BRICS countries touched USD 416 billion in CY2025 — registering nearly 10 per cent CAGR between CY2021 and CY2025 — the merchandise trade deficit with the bloc has almost doubled, rising from USD 117 billion in CY2021 to USD 224 billion in CY2025.

Rapid depreciation of the Indian currency against the US dollar and near-total dependence on imported crude oil and CNG have made the Indian economy highly vulnerable to external shocks. As New Delhi leans toward Washington's security and technology blocs, questions arise over its strategic autonomy, regional stability, and India's future in the BRICS+ bloc of emerging economies.



Honda's Hybrid Hope

Once the ultimate aspirational carmaker, Honda has battled shifting tastes, SUV mania and competition. Now, it is betting on hybrids and premium positioning

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

There was a time when owning a Honda meant you had arrived. This was not because Honda built the most flamboyant cars on the road. Quite the opposite. Honda represented something subtler and more powerful in an emerging India. Aspiration. In the late 1990s and early 2000s, when India's middle class was expanding and learning to spend with confidence, a Honda became a quick showcase for success and sophistication, without spectacle. This was the era before giant touchscreen displays, connected-car theatrics and social media-driven automobile hype... When buyers cared about engineering, refinement, reliability and credibility. Few global automakers embodied these qualities as convincingly as Honda.

Auto Mythology

It was at this time that Honda brought in products that cemented its mythology. The City became India's aspirational sedan, with the successful buying it after career leaps. Suddenly, it was found parked outside most apartments and offices with equal ease. The Civic was all flair and sporty sophistication. The Accord was luxury without complexity or intimidating service bills. The niche CR-V flaunted understated elegance among those who valued engineering over flashiness. Emotional trust. Its engines became benchmarks for smoothness and refinement. The VTEC badge entered enthusiast vocabulary almost as folklore. The cars were durable, dependable and smartly engineered. Owners never needed to justify their Honda; the badge itself conveyed judgement and class. And then, India began changing gears.

How India Changed

Today's Honda Cars occupy a peculiar position. Globally, Honda is still among the most respected automakers, admired for engineering excellence, technological capability and build quality. But in India, the company no longer dominates conversations, showroom traffic or sales charts the way it used to. This is not a story of failure or

irrelevance. It is a narration of how the auto market evolved, and how a highly respected company struggled to adapt to that transformation. No one can doubt Honda's golden legacy. Its early success in India was built on timing as much as technology. Economic reform created a middle class eager for wheels that reflected achievement without being ostentatious. Honda understood this psychology perfectly. The City, in particular, arrived at just the right moment. It was refinement, reliability and driving comfort wrapped in a package that felt premium compared to everything India's motorists had previously experienced. Sleek interiors, smooth engines and strong resale reinforced Honda's reputation for quality. For Indians, upgrading to a Honda became a milestone. Honda's credibility was built patiently. It was never a loud marketer, but its products spoke out. Even today, old Hondas run reliably, a testament to the engineering quality that built the brand's reputation. For two decades, that formula worked beautifully. But the market evolved faster than any auto firm anticipated.

SUV Revolution

The transformation arrived through SUVs. Consumers shifted away from sedans and clambered into taller, rugged-looking vehicles with imposing road presence. Suddenly, cars were no longer judged only by refinement, fuel efficiency or driving dynamics. Design language, technology, lifestyle positioning and visual appeal began driving buying decisions. Sensing the shift, manufacturers adapted ferociously. Hyundai Motor transformed the Creta into a segment-defining blockbuster. Kia entered India with the feature-loaded Seltos and razor-sharp marketing. Tata Motors reinvented itself around design and safety. Mahindra dominated the SUV space and enjoyed runaway success. Maruti Suzuki was everywhere, outselling everyone.

By comparison, Honda's response was cautious. The BR-V and WR-V found acceptance but never became disruptors. By the time the sensible and competent Elevate SUV arrived, the segment had become overcrowded and hyper-competitive. Honda was challenged by more than simply being late to the SUV race. For the very definition of automotive value had changed.

HONDA STILL BUILDS DEPENDABLE, REFINED CARS. BUT INDIA'S auto buyers WANT MORE THAN RELIABILITY — THEY WANT PRESENCE, PERSONALITY AND EXCITEMENT

Honda's traditional strengths — engineering refinement, reliability and driving quality — continued to differentiate the brand, but new buyers were looking through an emotional and technological lens. Touchscreens, connected features, panoramic sunroofs and bold styling began influencing buying decisions as much as the mechanics. Customers no longer wanted transportation. They wanted identity, visibility and aspiration. Honda's conservative philosophy appeared less exciting.

Quiet Strength

Despite slow sales, Honda still retains strengths that rivals have been struggling to replicate. The City is one of India's finest sedans. The Amaze is practical, refined and dependable. The Elevate offers comfort, usability and

strong driving dynamics. All benefit from naturally-aspirated petrol engines that enjoy goodwill. And importantly, trust in the brand remains remarkably resilient. Trust matters. Auto markets move in cycles. Trends may dominate temporarily, but reliability and ownership experience create long-term loyalty. Honda continues to benefit from a customer base that values these attributes. It also retains enormous technological prowess, particularly in hybrid systems, powertrain development and engineering research.

And this is beginning to show. Honda now appears to be signalling a serious hybrid-led push for renewed relevance. The just-unveiled City HEV reinforces the company's long-standing strength in refined electrified powertrains, while the upcoming Honda ZR-V HEV (deliveries are expected to begin in July) marks an ambitious attempt to enter India's premium SUV territory.

Expected to be priced upwards of Rs 40 lakh, the ZR-V will compete against the Jeep Meridian, Skoda Kodiaq, Volkswagen Tiguan and Audi Q3. The challenge now is not technological capability; it is whether Honda can translate engineering brilliance into emotional desirability and stronger market momentum.

Can it Screech Back?

Possibly, but the future demands urgency and reinvention. Honda does not need to abandon its identity. In fact, its strength still remains its credibility. Refinement, reliability and engineering mastery carry enormous value in a market crowded with feature-heavy products and marketing spiel. What Honda must do is modernise those strengths with packaging and communication.

Today's India rewards emotional engagement alongside mechanical competence. Buyers demand sharper styling, tech-rich interiors, connected ecosystems and faster product refreshes. Honda must combine its engineering excellence with a more assertive product and marketing strategy. The company also needs to leverage its hybrid tech more effectively. The City and forthcoming ZR-V HEV suggest Honda understands this imperative, though success will depend on pricing, positioning and the ability to rebuild aspirational appeal in a fiercely competitive SUV market.

Equally critical is visibility. Honda once shaped India's aspirations. Today, its revival needs more than nostalgia. It must marry its enduring strengths with customers' emotional and technological expectations. Its cars should not only be dependable and refined, but also impossible to ignore. In today's India, building a good car is not enough. You must also win the conversation around it.

WELLNESS

ONE INJECTION TO SILENCE ANXIETY?

The internet is calling PA-915 a revolutionary “anti-anxiety vaccine,” but science tells a far more complicated — and fascinating — story

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

Imagine waking up one morning without dread, sitting quietly in the background. No constant overthinking. No worst-case scenarios playing in loops before your day has even begun. Just quiet. Not because of years of therapy, not because of a pill, but because of a single injection you received weeks ago.

If I told you there was a miracle “vaccine” that could make anxiety disappear, would you take it? It sounds magical, right? Which is exactly why the internet exploded and swooned over it.

Over the past few weeks, social media has been flooded with headlines about the world's first “anti-anxiety vaccine.” But there is a very important asterisk attached to that phrase.

First Things First: It is Not Actually a Vaccine, It's a Molecule

The molecule behind the hype is called PA-915, which is being referred to as a vaccine. Technically, it is not one.

Vaccines work through the immune system. PA-915 works on the brain's stress-response system. It is a drug — a specially designed molecule developed by researchers in Japan that has so far only been tested in mice.

The word “vaccine” started circulating because researchers loosely described its potentially long-lasting effects after a single dose. Social media heard “vaccine,” saw a vial, and the rest went viral.

The distinction matters gravely. Vaccines are established public-health tools backed by decades of human data, while PA-915 is still early-stage neuroscience. Confusing the two shapes public expectations in dangerous ways. When people believe a cure is right around the corner, they sometimes stop pursuing the evidence-based help already available today in the form of therapy and medications.

Why Are We All Excited?

Your brain has a built-in stress alarm system. One of the molecules involved is called PACAP, which activates a receptor known as PAC1. This pathway helps trigger the cascade associated with anxiety and depression.

Most current medications, like SSRIs and SNRIs, work further downstream by indirectly adjusting serotonin levels. PA-915 attempts something different. It blocks the PAC1 receptor itself, theoretically stopping the stress cascade before the alarm fully rings.

In mouse studies, a single dose rapidly reduced anxiety- and depression-like symptoms, with effects lasting up to eight weeks. Researchers also reported no dependency,

cognitive dulling, sedation, or hyperactivity. In some stress tests, it even appeared to outperform fluoxetine, one of the world's most commonly prescribed antidepressants. For psychiatry, where many treatments take weeks to work and a significant number of patients never fully respond, these are genuinely exciting early findings.

The Part Everyone Keeps Forgetting

Everything above happened in mice. Not humans. Not psychiatric patients. Not real-world clinical settings.

Human anxiety is far more complicated than laboratory stress models. It is shaped by trauma, relationships, sleep, finances, personality, loneliness, physical health, and life experiences. Psychiatry is also full of compounds that looked revolutionary in animals but failed once tested in humans.

PA-915 has not entered a single human clinical trial yet. The journey from promising mouse data to an approved medication usually takes many years, involving safety testing, regulatory approvals, and large-scale clinical studies.

So no, you cannot sign up for it. No, your psychiatrist cannot prescribe it. And no, it is not arriving next year.

FOR MILLIONS living with anxiety disorders, the idea of a long-lasting injection that quiets the brain's stress alarms sounds almost utopian

Why This Story Went Viral Anyway

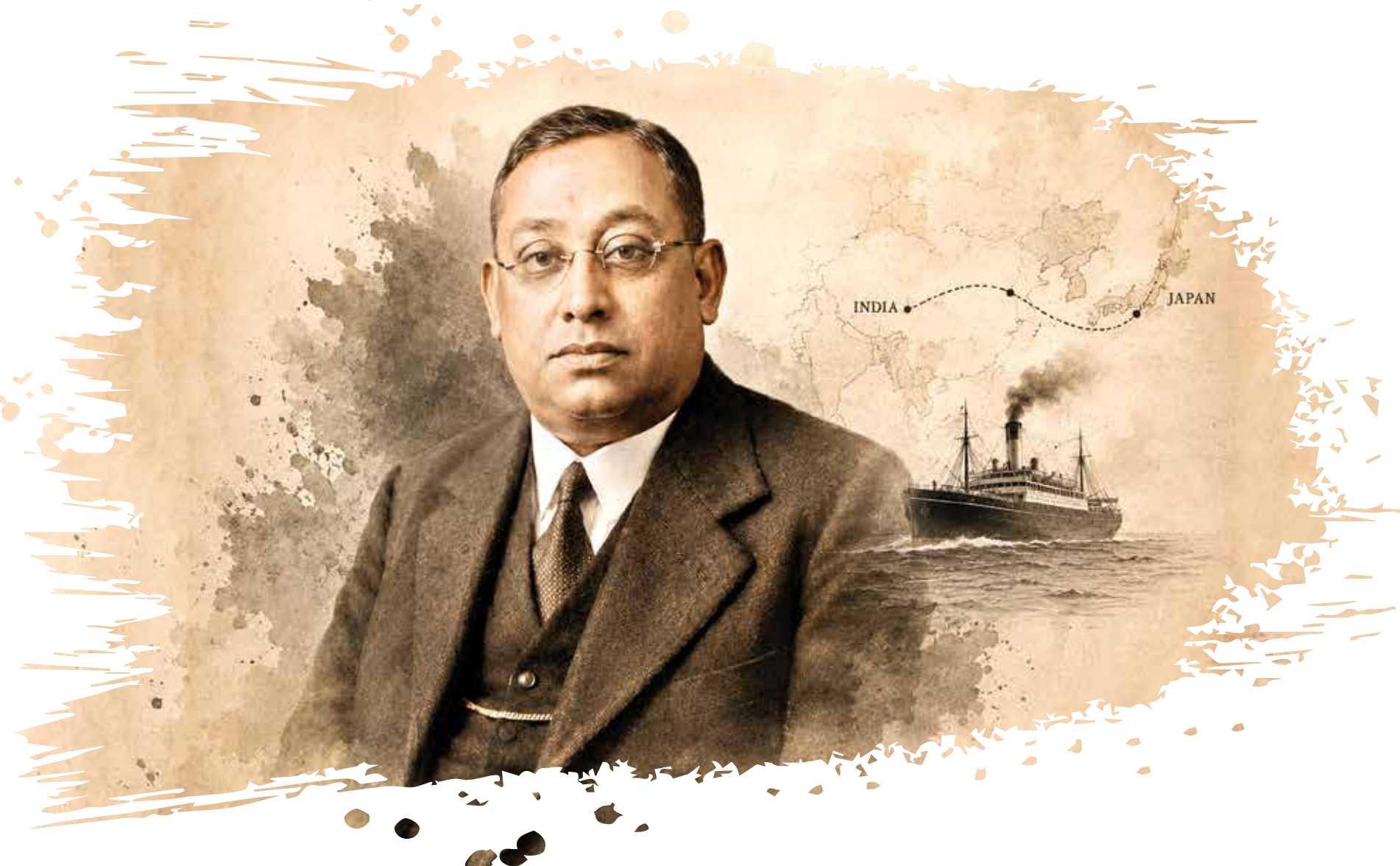
The public reaction says something important.

Anxiety and depression affect hundreds of millions of people globally. Existing treatments can be slow, expensive, inaccessible, or difficult to tolerate because of side effects. In countries like India, mental healthcare remains underfunded, while stigma still keeps many people from seeking help early.

The excitement around PA-915 is not irrational. It reflects how many people are exhausted, struggling, and desperate for something that finally works. The molecule may eventually live up to its promise. The research is absolutely worth following. But the conversation about your anxiety still belongs with a qualified clinician, not a viral reel or comment section.

And the next time social media promises to revolutionise mental health overnight, pause and take a deep breath. Wait for the comprehensive research to drop. Meanwhile, seeking help from a mental-health expert and combining the right approach of lifestyle management, therapy, and medication if needed, remains the most evidence-based approach for anxiety disorders that exists today, backed by robust data.





JAPAN'S HONOUR FOR BOSE

In 1943, the Japanese government awarded Rash Behari Bose the prestigious **ORDER OF THE RISING SUN**, among Japan's highest honours. Even after his death in Tokyo in 1945, Japanese respect for him endured. His funeral reportedly received rare ceremonial recognition from the Japanese establishment.



The Revolutionary History Overlooked

AUTHOR



AMITABHA CHANDA

Long before the INA captured public imagination, Rash Behari Bose had already transformed India's anti-colonial struggle into a global revolutionary movement

History, in its selective generosity, often crowns a few names with immortality while leaving others in the penumbra of undeserved obscurity. Among those towering figures whose contributions to India's freedom struggle remain grievously underappreciated stands Rash Behari Bose – a man of extraordinary daring, intellectual agility, conspiratorial brilliance, and remarkable international vision, whose life reads less like a conventional biography and more like an epic of intrigue, exile, sacrifice, and revolutionary fire. Much of the biographical material on Rash Behari Bose reflects varying accounts and historical inconsistencies, but the broad arc of his revolutionary life remains indisputable.

To speak of India's freedom movement solely through the familiar vocabulary of petitions, parliamentary negotiation, and civil disobedience is to narrate only one chapter of a far larger saga. Parallel to the constitutional movement ran another stream – secretive, dangerous, uncompromising, and soaked in personal peril. Rash Behari Bose belonged unmistakably to that fierce tradition.

Born in Bengal on May 25, 1886, Rash Behari emerged from an era when patriotism was not a fashionable sentiment but a punishable offence. British India was not merely a political arrangement; it was a structure of humiliation. A generation of educated Indians had begun to recognise that beneath the polished rhetoric of imperial "civilisation" lay a machinery of racial arrogance and systematic subjugation.

For the young Rash Behari, nationalism was not an abstract ideological indulgence. It was visceral. Stories suggest that even in his youth, he was deeply offended by the discriminatory exclusion of Indians – particularly Bengalis – from the military service. That humiliation left an imprint. He developed an intense interest in physical fitness, discipline, and martial preparedness, unusual traits in a colonial milieu where the British had carefully cultivated stereotypes of the "effete Bengali."

His education was irregular, and by conventional academic standards, he may not have appeared destined for greatness.

But history is often written not by the obedient classroom prodigy, but by the restless dissenter.

His eventual association with revolutionary circles transformed youthful defiance into organised resistance. In Chandernagore, then under French administration and therefore somewhat freer from direct British surveillance, he came into contact with nationalist revolutionaries linked to Bengal's underground movement. It was here that his latent rebellion found structure.

The first great public tremor of his revolutionary genius came in 1912.

On 23 December of that year, as Lord Hardinge, the Viceroy of India, entered Delhi in ceremonial grandeur, a bomb exploded in an audacious assassination attempt that shook the foundations of the British Raj. The symbolism was electrifying. The Empire, draped in pomp and imperial arrogance, had suddenly discovered its vulnerability.

Though operational details remain debated in historical retellings, Rash Behari Bose was widely recognised as one of the principal masterminds behind the conspiracy. What elevated the episode into legend was not merely the attack, but the breathtaking calm with which Bose allegedly resumed normal life immediately afterwards, even participating in public condemnation of the incident to deflect suspicion.

That was quintessential Rash Behari: theatrical audacity paired with cold strategic intelligence. The Hardinge episode catapulted him into the foremost ranks of revolutionary leadership. But his vision extended beyond symbolic acts of terror.

By the outbreak of the First World War, Bose recognised what many political leaders did not: empires are most vulnerable when distracted by larger conflicts. The war offered opportunity. British military resources were stretched. Indian troops were deployed overseas. Revolutionary groups abroad, particularly the Ghadar movement – composed largely of expatriate Indians from North America – were increasingly eager to trigger an armed uprising.

Rash Behari Bose emerged as the natural organiser of this grand design. The proposed insurrection of 1915 was breathtaking in ambition. It was not a local conspiracy. It was conceived as a pan-Indian military revolt involving army cantonments across multiple regions,

coordinated sabotage, infiltration of regiments, and synchronised rebellion. This was not romantic amateurism. It was sophisticated revolutionary planning. Yet history is often cruel to conspiracies. Betrayal intervened.

The plot was compromised before execution. British intelligence acted swiftly. Arrests followed. Executions ensued. The revolution collapsed before ignition. For lesser men, such failure would have meant obscurity, imprisonment, or surrender.

For Rash Behari Bose, it meant reinvention. His escape from India itself has become part of nationalist lore. Under an assumed identity, he fled to Japan in 1915, under the alias of

P. N. Tagore (secretary of Rabin-dratanath Tagore), beginning one of the most extraordinary exilic chapters in the history of anti-colonial struggle.

In Japan, life was initially precarious. Britain, then allied with Japan, sought his extradition. He lived as a fugitive, changing residences repeatedly, navigating surveillance, diplomatic pressure, and uncertainty. Yet exile did not diminish him. It enlarged him. Many revolutionaries become prisoners of nostalgia when separated from their homeland. Rash Behari became something rarer – an international strategist. Gradually integrating into Japanese society, learning the language, writing extensively, and engag-

ing in cultural life, he transformed himself from hunted conspirator into respected political interlocutor. His marriage into the sympathetic Soma family was not merely a personal turning point; it symbolised the extraordinary human alliances that sustained his journey. Even in exile, India remained his central preoccupation. He understood something profoundly modern: anti-colonial struggle required global networks.

Long before "international solidarity" became a fashionable political vocabulary, Rash Behari was practising it. He saw that India's liberation could not remain geographically provincial. It had to engage shifting geopolitical realities. This foresight became crucial during the Second World War. Once again, global war destabilised imperial certainties. Japan's rapid military expansion across Southeast Asia created unprecedented strategic possibilities. Thousands of Indian soldiers, captured as prisoners of war by Japanese forces, suddenly became a potential liberation army. Rash Behari Bose seized the moment again.

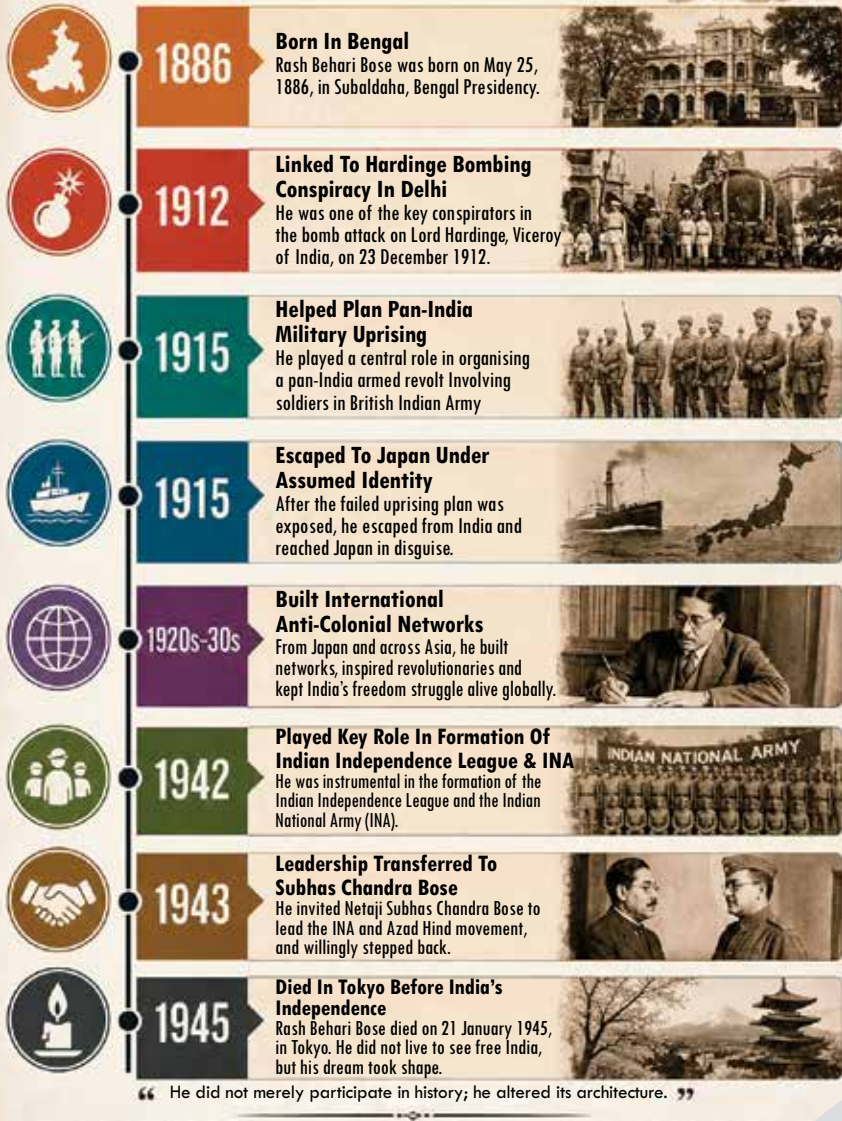
It was through his tireless efforts, alongside figures such as Captain Mohan Singh and others, that the Indian Independence League gained structure and the embryonic Indian National Army came into being. And here lies perhaps his greatest historical generosity. Many revolutionaries cling jealously to leadership. Rash Behari relinquished it. Recognising that the movement required a figure of electrifying mass charisma, he invited Subhas Chandra Bose to assume leadership. That decision was not merely tactical. It was profoundly selfless. When Netaji arrived and the Azad Hind movement acquired global prominence, Rash Behari willingly stepped aside, allowing the younger, more dynamic leader to occupy centre stage. History often remembers the climactic performer more vividly than the architect who built the stage.

That is precisely what happened. Netaji deservedly became immortal in the public imagination. Rash Behari receded into historical shadow.

Yet without Rash Behari Bose, the international infrastructure that enabled the later Azad Hind experiment might never have existed. His contributions were not confined to conspiracy or militarism. He represented a fascinating ideological synthesis. He was intensely nationalist, yet not narrowly chauvinistic. He believed in international cooperation. He moved fluidly between cultures.

RASH BEHARI BOSE A TIMELINE

REVOLUTIONARY. STRATEGIST. EXILE. ARCHITECT OF FREEDOM.



DESPITE HIS EXTRAORDINARY ROLE IN SHAPING INDIA'S anti-colonial STRUGGLE, HE REMAINS ONE OF THE LEAST DISCUSSED GIANTS OF THE FREEDOM MOVEMENT

He rejected parochialism.

At a time when political identities were often imprisoned within provincial loyalties, Rash Behari operated with astonishing geographic breadth – from Bengal to Punjab, from Dehradun to Benares, from Tokyo to Southeast Asia. He was, in many ways, one of the earliest truly transnational Indian revolutionaries. His life also complicates simplistic moral narratives. Modern readers, understandably shaped by democratic values, may feel discomfort with revolutionary violence. That discomfort is legitimate. But historical judgment requires contextual honesty. Colonial regimes were not benign administrators politely awaiting persuasion. They were coercive structures sustained by racial hierarchy, legal repression, economic extraction, and violence.

For many revolutionaries of that era, armed struggle did not appear immoral. It appeared necessary. One may debate their methods. One cannot dismiss their patriotism. Rash Behari Bose died in Tokyo on 21 January 1945, before India finally achieved independence. There is something deeply tragic in that chronology. A man who devoted his entire adult life to dismantling an empire never witnessed its collapse. A revolutionary who crossed continents for India died in foreign soil. And yet perhaps tragedy is not the correct word. Perhaps fulfilment is. For he had already seen his dream take institutional form.

He had helped create an armed liberation movement. He had inspired generations. He had internationalised India's struggle. He had transformed exile into resistance. Japan honoured him. Independent India, arguably, has remembered him far less than he deserves. This neglect reflects a larger national habit. We simplify history because nuance is inconvenient. We prefer a few monumental icons because collective memory likes manageable narratives. But nations impoverish themselves when they forget complexity.

Rash Behari Bose deserves remembrance not merely as a precursor to Netaji, nor merely as a bomb conspirator, nor merely as a fugitive patriot. He deserves recognition as one of the great strategic minds of India's liberation struggle. He was a man of astonishing resilience, a conspirator with intellectual depth, a nationalist without provincial narrowness, a revolutionary who understood geopolitics, and a patriot who sacrificed anonymity for freedom. If history is indeed a moral conversation between past and present, then our conversation with Rash Behari Bose is long overdue, for some men do not merely participate in history; they alter its architecture.

A Journey Through the Occult



Drawing from Bangla ghost lore, colonial Gothic fiction and modern social anxieties, Creeping Shadows transforms the supernatural into a powerful meditation on patriarchy, violence, class and memory

NAMITA SETHI

Creeping Shadows is an anthology of 13 stories by Aruna Chakravarti that explore the unknown and the supernatural in their varied avatars. There are stories about ghosts, but there are also stories about possession, demonic forces, nature entities, clairvoyance, dreams, astral travel, poltergeists, hauntings, exorcism, black magic and other phenomena that cannot be explained rationally. Chakravarti, who has taught English and writes prolifically in English, quotes from Shakespeare's play *Hamlet*, in one of the stories to validate her explorations:

Don't forget what Hamlet said to Horatio? There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, than are dreamt of in your philosophy"

Though she draws upon some of the conventions of Bangla ghost fiction as well as colonial English ghost stories, the end product seems quite original. She confessed at an interview at IIC that she has no first-hand experience of encounters with the supernatural or of "seeing" ghosts. Her stories are very dramatic and visual in the images and fears they evoke. This is to be expected, as not only has Chakravarti deftly portrayed nineteenth- and 20th-century Bengal in her previous novels and fiction, but she has also brought these representations to life in her scriptwriting, as a producer of multimedia presentations, and through dramatised readings of her works. She claims, in an interview with Mitali Chakravarty, that she was taking a break from the "mould of historical fiction" and wanted to write stories based on imagination, rather than research. However, the stories are intricately embedded in socio-historical contexts ranging from 19th-century Calcutta, a tea house in 1820s China, pre and post-independence Bangladesh and India, as well as contemporary Delhi, with identifiable locales.

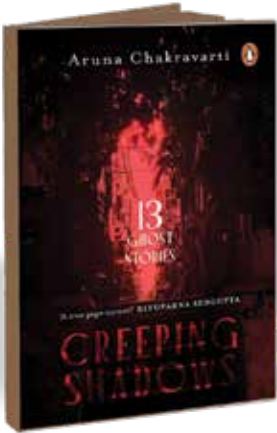
The stories begin innocuously, lulling the reader through the tropes of historical fiction at times, but are always perceptive and precise in their social satire. They then build up in intensity, seamlessly toppling the reader into the world of varied, inexplicable forces and end by disorienting the reader.

Just as Aristotle finds a pleasure proper to the genre of Tragedy with its accompaniment of catharsis and knowledge, ghost stories produce the pleasure of terror and chills down the spine, which a longer narrative might make more gruesome and depressing. As Chakravarti herself describes this literary effect in her story "Grandmother's Bundle":

We loved all her stories but the ones we enjoyed most, the ones that sent thrills of pleasurable terror down our spines, were her ghost stories. Especially her petni and shankhchunni stories. I don't think there are any English names for these supernatural beings. But, for want of better equivalents, let's call them female ghosts or she-demons.

Chakravarti references the fact that these feminine entities, along with other ghosts and demons, are "humanised" by "We Bengalis" (CS, Grandmother's Bundle, p. 126). They are endowed with likes and dislikes and even "given religion and castes: A mamdo bhoot was once a Muslim male. A Brahmin, in life, becomes a brahmadatyai after death." (p.128)

Ghosts and shapeshifters have a rich history of literary presence in Bangla literature: from the medieval writer Mukundaram Chakravarty to the famous 1907 work *Thakurmar Jhuli*



THIS IS A DISTINCTIVE COLLECTION THAT BOTH DRAWS ON literary CONVENTIONS AND DEPARTS FROM IT IN INTERESTING WAYS

(Grandmother's Bag of Tales) by Dakshinaranjan Mitra Majumdar, for which Rabindranath Tagore wrote an introduction. Read by children and adults alike, Bangla fairytales and ghost stories feature creatures with distinct food preferences. Ghosts who love fish include *Mecho Bhoot* and *Petnis*, who are often unmarried or women who were young widows and denied fish in their lifetime. *Shankhchunnis* are ghosts of married women and usually prefer milk and sweets. Chakravarti gives this story a feminist slant. We are told that the *petnis* and *shankhchunnis* do not really harm humans, they were simply "lazy and greedy":

But that could be because, when alive, they didn't get enough to eat. Like all malnourished women, they were brainwashed into believing that their duty as good wives and mothers was to feed their husbands and children to satiety and eat whatever scrapings were left in the pot.

As a result, the narrator and the reader deduce that social mechanisms for controlling women's mobility and appetites are far scarier than the demons, who teach the valuable lesson of sisterhood:

Because, Thammi explained, sisters, whether human or spectral, are supposed to love and bond with each other.

While "Grandmother's Bundle" is one of the few humorous and lighthearted ghost stories, there are others that are bloodcurdling. In "One Winter Night", set in Purnea of 1957, the story begins happily enough with the celebration of the Bangla harvest festival of Makar Sankranti and the *Tush Tushulir Brata*. By the end of the story, the good doctor Dibanath is attacked by the ghosts of the ati shudras as he goes out of his way to tend to the sick. The story features this unjust attack only after exposing the callousness of the upper-caste rich communities of Bengal and Bihar towards the "achyuts" or untouchables and the

great economic divide that separates them. Two of the stories are about prostitutes: "The House of Flowers" and "Possessed". The former, set in China and reminiscent of Pearl S. Buck's stories, tells us of a courtesan called Snow Lily, so called because "the gentlest touch will leave a bruise". Ironically, it is her ghost that leaves a bruise by biting off a big piece of Zihan's shoulder. The patriarchal set-up continues in the Chinese household more than a century after migration to Calcutta, where the disabled daughter of the house is treated cruelly. A very different effect is achieved in "Possessed", a story that brings to life 19th-century Calcutta and the Bengal National Theatre, founded by the famous director, playwright and actor Girish Ghosh. The story vividly describes Sonagachi, Calcutta's largest brothel (set in the 1860s):

A world in itself; a small, dim airless world where women were trapped in ill ventilated rooms and peddled their bodies for a few annas each night.

As the courtesan protagonist emerges from these muddy waters to be very popular and successful at her profession, we learn of her desire to be an actress as well as the strange episodes of spirit possession in her life. The story climaxes with the appearance of the ghost of the great 18th-century British actress Sarah Siddons on the stage when Teenkari performs the role of Lady Macbeth in a Bangla adaptation of Shakespeare's play. The haunted musings arising out of Lady Macbeth's guilt are blended with the theme of spirit possession with dramatic flourish, making this one of the most striking pieces in the anthology. In "House of Flowers" the courtesan is a violent ghost, but in "Possessed", the courtesan figure is herself a victim and artist. In fact, "Possessed" functions as a metaphor for the act of creation and performance itself.

"Vendetta" is again a very different story, where a tree and monkeys seem to avenge their destruction by a scientist who works for the Pusa Institute. Though the ecocritical dimension is fascinating, with all the many varieties of apes described, the ending of the story is quite disturbing, with all the wild force of nature against man.

There is the spectral rider on a motorcycle in a recognisable university in Delhi, but as is typical of Chakravarti, the story gives space to the side plot of a hypocritical academic, who leaves his wife, also a professor, to handle the housework and caregiving. He is indifferent to his students' welfare as well. The ghost sighting leaves the reader less scared than campus and domestic politics.

A serpentine necklace takes on a life of its own, sucking the life out of an Anglo-Indian Calcutta girl, who dares to reject a princely suitor. In "Caregivers of Gazipur", set against the creation of Bangladesh in 1971, the ghostly shadows loom over a landscape of social injustice and religious conversion. The 1984 anti-Sikh riots form the tragic backdrop for the appearance of a chivalrous Sikh father and his gang-raped daughter (on a busy flyover in Delhi) in "There are More Things in Heaven and Earth".

There are characters who are drawn into familial relationships and friendships with ghosts, only to have their strength drain out of them. Chakravarti added two stories to the original 11 to arrive at the spooky number 13. Each story uses a different setting, a different trajectory and yet most of them achieve the intended effect of sending chills down one's spine. The present participle in the title *Creeping Shadows* is therefore appropriate in more senses than one.

Bodies Adrift in a Cruel World



Translated from Hindi by Mahua Sen, The Dead Fish is a psychologically unsettling exploration of trauma, sexuality and moral decay in post-Independence India

YAUVANIKA CHOPRA

"It rained. Water flooded the dried-up river... The dead blue fish came back to life." The journey of a man begins with his family. Ten-year-old Nirmal was thrown out of his house in the village, on the banks of the Padmavati, after his mother eloped with a lorry driver. Alone, he found his way to Karachi and through various odd jobs - selling newspapers, selling tea - grew into labour and enterprise. Then Bombay, New York, Calcutta; proletariat becoming bourgeoisie through shrewd loans, ruthless deals, and ever-accruing profit. It is a meteoric rise to success. "But why does even a man of this stature turn fragile, vulnerable and insane at some juncture in life?"

A boy who never experiences the fullness of love, through his mother or any other familial sources which are supposed to provide unconditional acceptance to the vulnerable young, realises that the worth of a man, in the eyes of the world, is determined by his purchasing power. He becomes impassive externally because internal fear must be tightly controlled. All the while, inferiority runs unabated through his veins, interrupted by the dazzle of money and power.

Rajkamal Choudhary, as Arun Kamal informs us in the Foreword, was from the disillusioned "Hungry Generation" in the 1960s, when hope for a new country was fading in the face of brutal authority structures. The establishment had proved itself to be fundamentally corrupt; literature - and authors - were mutinous against it. In his own Author's Note, Choudhary writes about two women from a friend's family who "were taken to the hospital together on account of mental health issues." Although he goes on to say that there is no such reality in his novel, *The Dead Fish* is unsettlingly realistic. "Kalyani Mansion" does not exist anywhere in Calcutta, but when the narrative mentions that this fictitious thirty-storey skyscraper built by our protagonist Nirmal Padmavat had been inaugurated by Dr Bidhan Chandra Ray (actual contemporaneous chief minister of West Bengal at the time), artifice bleeds into art: "On behalf of the people of Calcutta, I extend my gratitude to the famous industrialist, Shri Nirmal Babu for constructing Kalyani Mansion..."

The building had been named after Nirmal's bewitching muse Kalyani, who had come to America to study medicine before becoming a bohemian model looking for new horizons in New York's Shangri La: "Her eyes sparkled like a goldfish when she laughed." Again, the narrative assures us that there is no way two fictitious people of such peculiarities could have ever actually met. And there are indeed other coincidences in the plot which are so improbable that they must have been drawn from imagination, but are characterized with disturbingly vivid psychological insight.

"People would say that Nirmal was obsessed with money, and they would consider him a patient of neurosis. Nirmal Padmavat, however, never bothered about his madness, his disease or people's perception of him. He continued doing what he had already decided. He continued trying to decipher and decrypt the world around him. He transformed his mind into a bare, sharp sword, poised to cut through the layers of darkness, scattering shards of light at his feet." Perception varies across personality, but Nirmal is considered cruel by most. To a man whose wife, Shirin, has left him for Nirmal: "Padmavat is not a human being but a frightful monster. He is not a human,

rather he's the great poet Goethe's Mephisto, Shakespeare's Othello, Emily Brontë's Heathcliff. This man is the devil."

Shirin Salzberg-Mehta-Padmavat is introduced in the novel as an eighteen-year-old singer at an upscale restaurant: "The boys of Calcutta / They know how to net a fish / They really know..." After her first husband, Shirin searches for water again with Nirmal: "She feels as if Nirmal is pushing her into a dark cave—the dark cave of death. There are poisonous animals in the cave. There are numerous snakes and she has been turned into a fish that has been pulled out of the sea. A blue fish. An unconscious fish. A fish thirsting for water. But the cave is dark... There is no ray of light left anywhere." And when, again, union between husband and wife is left unconsummated because of the husband's unresolved shadows, the wife's thwarted lust becomes physical anger: "Shirin opened her eyes, and extending her hand, tried to get a hold of Nirmal. She yearned to drink him in. But it was already too late. The piece of ice had now melted into water, and it did not take long for water to turn into steam and evaporate into thin air... Shirin leapt out like a fish after tearing the net and dove into Nirmal's scattered, broken body. She began to beat Nirmal's body with both her hands."

Shirin is the starving cat; Shirin is the dead fish.

Morality and sin are equal addictions in this strange novel by Rajkamal Choudhary. The hidden is revealed in maladaptive sexuality, sadism presents as generosity, conscience and consciousness spiral into disarray. The daughter of Kalyani (and the Doctor she had eventually married) is Priya — young, tender, curious. But the darkness of the world inhabited in that time and space spares nothing and nobody.

"Just a silhouette of two women. There were no arms, no hands, no fingers, no knees, no legs, just two fish. Blue fish. And the sea of darkness." The lesbian relationship in this book is contextualised by the omniscient narrator through literary precedents in the works of Marquis de Sade, Alphonse Daudet, and Radclyffe Hall. In particular, the novel *Wind Woman* by Carol Hales (1953) becomes a point of similarity. But there is surprisingly no reference here (or earlier in the Author's Preface written in 1965) to Indian authors like Ismat Chughtai, despite the very public controversy and court case she faced in 1944 for "obscenity" in 'Lihaf'.

Rajkamal Choudhary's fragmented writing is discomfiting because it echoes reality. Another searing text by a Hindi playwright who emerged in the mid-1960s is Swadesh Deepak's memoir *Maine Mandu Nahin Dekha* (translated by Jerry Pinto as *I Have Not Seen Mandu; Speaking Tiger* 2021). That too is a portrait of a man and his relationships which, once read, is difficult to forget. Amongst Deepak's other brilliant short stories is 'Paapi Pair' — 'Sinful Stomach. But what is crime in a cruel world? When does desperation cross into depravity and to what degree can it be understood through compassion? How do hurt people heal without scarring further? Where does literature get entangled in this vicious web as virtue?"

Character is defined by circumstance. To close, the last paragraph of Jayanta Mahapatra's haunting poem "Hunger" from 1976, evoked by the title of Choudhary's book: "I heard him say: My daughter, she's just turned fifteen... / Feel her. I'll be back soon, your bus leaves at nine. / The sky fell on me, and a father's exhausted wile. / Long and lean, her years were cold as rubber. / She opened her wormy legs wide. I felt the hunger there, / the other one, the fish slithering, turning inside."



IN THE DEAD FISH, DESIRE, MADNESS AND CLASS ambition COLLIDE IN A HAUNTING PORTRAIT OF MODERN ALIENATION

'It is not on purpose'

Bollywood filmmaker Imtiaz Ali opened up about tragic endings in his films

Filmmaker Imtiaz Ali said that the recurring tragic endings in his films are not a conscious choice but an organic outcome of storytelling. His films have repeatedly left audiences with bittersweet or heartbreaking conclusions - from the doomed romance of 'Rockstar' to the tragic real-life arc of 'Amar Singh Chamkila'.

"I don't do it on purpose; it just happens. A lot of things that we do in this work just happen. A lot of the things that I do are not guided by the intellect. It feels like the stories are just being written by me," Ali, also known for films like 'Jab We Met', 'Love Aaj

Kal', 'Highway' and 'Tamasha', told the reporters.

The director spoke at the trailer launch event of his new film, 'Main Vaapas Aaunga'. The film, set against the backdrop of the Partition of India, follows a young man (Vedang Raina) who falls in love with a woman (Sharvari) in the pre-Partition era - a story that unfolds across two timelines, with Naseeruddin Shah essaying the older version of the character and Diljit Dosanjh playing his grandson.

'Main Vaapas Aaunga' reunites the director with composer AR Rahman and lyricist

Irshad Kamil after they delivered a melodious soundtrack for films like Amar Singh Chamkila, 'Rockstar',



'Tamasha' and 'Highway'.

Rahman described his collaboration with Kamil and Ali as intuitive rather than formula-driven. "We never discuss anything. We just saw the film and discussed the possibilities of what we can do. I have a few ideas and I play them to Ali and he will say, 'I'll like this' and then we ask Irshad sahab to give some lyrics and something comes," he said.

"We just dive deep into and extract something. It's not formulaic; the story and the vision lead there," the composer said.

'Main Vaapas Aaunga' marks the second collaboration between Ali and Dosanjh after their 2024 widely loved 'Netflix' film 'Amar Singh Chamkila'.

Dosanjh, who couldn't attend the event as he is touring in the US, urged audiences in a video message to watch and share the film's trailer. "If you like the trailer, do share it. If you don't, still share it because it's an Imtiaz Ali film," the actor-singer said, adding that his show in Texas was sold out.

Veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah underscored the importance of writing and direction in shaping performances and heaped praise on Ali, with whom he has collaborated for the first time. "I believe that an actor's success depends on the writer and director. If

the writing is not correct, even the best actor in the world can't do anything; I'm a living example of this. I've done bad work in many films and my sons wake me up at 3 am on 'YouTube' and tell me, 'A film of yours is being played,'" Shah said.

"Imtiaz has written a very good script. The dialogues are beautiful and the situations are powerful. I've seen his previous films, which I liked a lot. He has worked with actors with a lot of love and care," he said, adding that Ali is among the few directors who prefer retakes for enhancing a performance.

"I'm very much looking forward to watching your film," the actor said.

Ali, in turn, fondly recalled his first meeting with Shah. "I was told that you are a very serious actor. But when I met you, all your attention was on why I am not drinking tea - is the tea not good? Then I understood that there is no need to take it too seriously. He is a normal person," he said.

The director also revealed that Shah's portrayal of a Sikh character has received widespread appreciation in early screenings. "I was very fascinated and excited to see you in a turban, playing a Sikh man, which I've never seen you do in life. Everybody who has watched the film in the rough cut has loved you the most in this film," Ali said.

Vedang Raina said portraying the younger version of Shah in the film was a big responsibility and an honour. He said observing Shah and Dosanjh on set was the most valuable learning experience. "I'm a big fan of him. When I auditioned in 2018-19, I watched Naseer sir's masterclass videos on acting and took notes on everything he said about acting," he said.

Sharvari Wagh, who plays Raina's love interest in the film, credited Ali's understanding of human emotions for shaping her performance. "I leaned on him to guide me. He understands human nature so well that it's exciting and interesting to see what he is thinking about food. There's so much that you can observe from him. I wanted to know from him about the film and about life. I'm a far more evolved person after meeting and hearing him. We've had great moments; he is funny. I'm grateful for this opportunity."

Wagh also praised the way Ali writes female characters. "It's an honour to be working with Imtiaz sir. The way he writes women in his films, they are so layered. He sees emotions in cinema beautifully," she said.

Both Wagh and Raina highlighted Ali's calm and precise directing style and said that he never scolds his actors. "His best quality is his calmness; he is precise. He is a gem. He is in his element and when he is directing, it's the most precious thing," Raina said.

Produced by 'Birla Studios' and 'Applause Entertainment' along with Mohit Choudhary, Shibashish Sarkar of 'Window Seat Films', the movie will release in theatres on June 12. PTI

EVERYONE WAS DOUBTFUL: SAIF ALI KHAN

The actor remembered playing the role of Langda Tyagi in Vishal Bhardwaj's 'Omkaara'

Saif Ali Khan vividly remembers the time when he was talking to his mother, veteran star Sharmila Tagore, on the phone and she asked him to do a Shakespearean adaptation, notably 'Othello'. And the very next call he received was from filmmaker Vishal Bhardwaj, who offered him the Langda Tyagi role in 'Omkaara'.

"I thought, 'What is going on?'" Saif recalled, reflecting on the overwhelming praise he received for his performance in Bhardwaj's Hindi heartland adaptation of 'Othello'.

At the time, the actor was shooting for Vidhu Vinod Chopra's 2007 movie 'Eklavya' in Jaipur, Rajasthan.

"I was staying at the lovely Rambagh hotel and one day, I was sitting on the lawn in the morning, having breakfast and my mom was talking to me and she said, 'You're doing well now. You're acting well. I'm very pleased with how things are going. I think you should do Shakespeare, like 'Othello' or something'. So, I was like, 'That would be interesting, thanks mom'. And I hung up. Just then, the phone rang and it was Vishal Bhardwaj saying, 'I want to come and see you. I've 'Othello,' Saif told PTI in an interview.

The actor said he asked the filmmaker if he could play the titular role in the movie.

"Bhardwaj said, 'No, it's not Othello. It's Lago. He's very good like this and said, 'I find you very handsome looking and Othello is slightly complex in the way he looks. So, you can't do that. But listen to what I have in mind,'" Saif recounted.

Released in July 2006, 'Omkaara' is widely regarded as one of Hindi cinema's finest Shakespearean adaptations, transplanting the tragedy of 'Othello' to the political badlands of Uttar Pradesh. The film featured Ajay Devgn in the title role, with Saif playing the scheming Langda Tyagi alongside Kareena Kapoor, Vivek Oberoi and Konkona Sen Sharma.

Saif's performance earned him the Filmfare Award for 'Best Supporting Actor' and is widely counted among the finest of his career.

Asked what made Bhardwaj cast him as the antagonist in the movie, the actor said, "He told me, 'I saw 'Dil Chahta Hai'. I think you can do it'. I don't know. He saw something evil in my portrayal of Sameer. So, we did it."

Saif praised the filmmaker for always having faith in him.

"Everyone was doubtful, but he was very kind and supportive and helped me with the dialogues. I did a lot of homework. I was on holiday in the Maldives and people were like, 'Why



Saif's performance earned him the Filmfare Award for 'Best Supporting Actor' and is widely counted among the finest of his career

don't you rehearse in the heartland?' I was reading this script under an umbrella in the Maldives, learning all these lines and kept practising. Then I came back."

He remembered nailing the first shot he gave for the movie.

"It was a nice scene with the great Deepak Dobriyal. Then everyone on the set started calling me 'Khan sahab', which was their way of saying that you can do it."

Now 20 years later, Saif said he is still reaping the rewards of 'Omkaara'. He currently stars in the 'Netflix' cop drama 'Kartavya'.

"The film has done so much for me and I'll always be thankful. It expresses a certain range to a bunch of filmmakers, who would otherwise think that I can't do it. They've said, 'Okay, if he's done that, then he can do this'. I like playing roles like this in 'Kartavya', which is not like 'Omkaara',

but it's a little grounded, rooted and very different to my personality. But that's the whole point of acting. So, it's nice if you can be free enough to have your own accent and your own body language and not try and convince people that actually you can be different," he said. PTI



'WHO'S YOUR GYNAC?' SEASON 2: THE ULTIMATE FAMILIAL COMFORT BINGE!

The new season dives deeper into conversations about friendships and family dynamics, while balancing humour and sensitivity with depth

Amazon MX Player brings back its heart-felt dramedy 'Who's Your Gynac?' with a second season that is warmer, deeper and far more resonant. Continuing Dr Vidushi Kothari's journey as she navigates modern womanhood, evolving relationships and the realities of emotional well-being with honesty and warmth, the brand-new season dives deeper into conversations about friendships and family dynamics, while balancing humour and sensitivity with depth.

Led by Saba Azad alongside Karishma Singh and Aaron Arjun Koul, backed by a stellar ensemble cast featuring Kunal Thakur, Vibha Chibber and Shruti Seth, the series delivers a deeply relatable and comforting viewing experience.

Here are four reasons why 'Who's Your Gynac?' S2 deserves to be on your watchlist:

Bigger, bolder & more emotional: After striking a chord



with audiences through its refreshing take on healthcare, friendships and modern womanhood in Season 1, the new season raises the emotional stakes beautifully. This time, the storytelling feels more layered and intimate, allowing every character to grow through moments of vulnerability, uncertainty and personal change.

Bringing every emotion to life: Saba Azad returns effortlessly as the lovable yet emotionally conflicted Dr Vidushi Kothari, alongside Karishma

Singh and Aaron Arjun Koul, as the trio navigates changing equations, emotional misunderstandings and life-altering moments. Kunal Thakur, Vibha Chibber and Shruti Seth further elevate the narrative with performances that feel honest, lived-in and deeply relatable. Together, the ensemble makes every friendship, family dynamic and emotional conflict feel incredibly real and relatable.

Mature & deeply evolved relationships: The new season beautifully captures how

relationships evolve with time, responsibility and emotional growth. Whether it's Vidushi struggling with feelings of inadequacy in her relationship with Arth, Swara battling her own emotional storms or the tender yet overprotective bond between Vidushi and Papa Kothari, every equation feels grounded and authentic. The show understands that love often exists in the smallest gestures, difficult conversations and simply showing up for one another.

A heartfelt dramedy: From awkward life moments to emotional breakdowns, wholesome friendships and heartwarming family dynamics, 'Who's Your Gynac?' Season 2 strikes the perfect balance between light-hearted entertainment and vulnerability as the world of Dr Vidushi Kothari is ready to welcome audiences back with even more heart.

The clinic is open again and this time, the emotions run even deeper!

MPOST